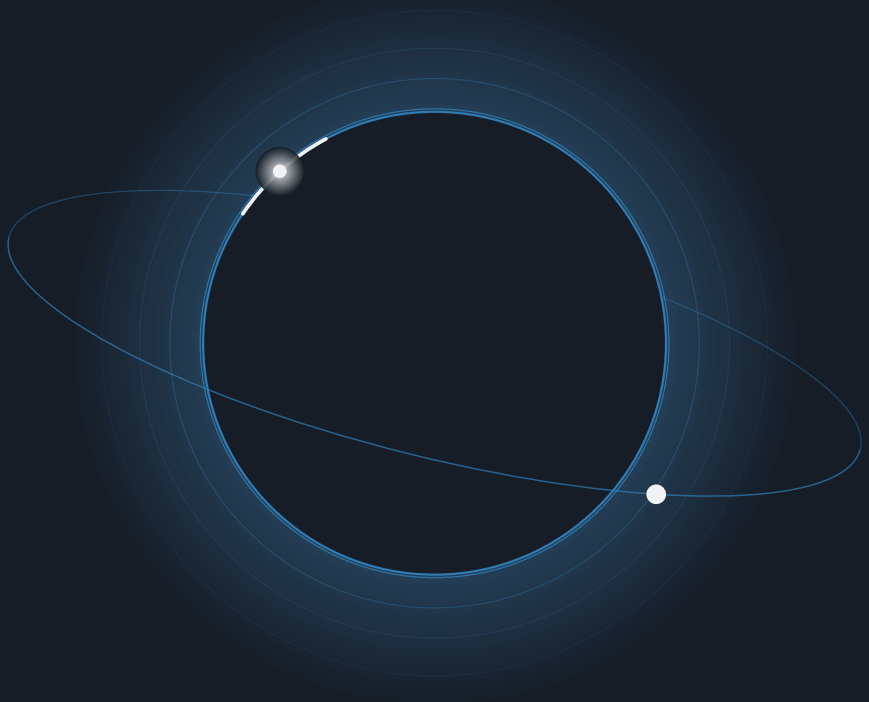
代理人



Cogito, ergo ~~sum~~ proxy

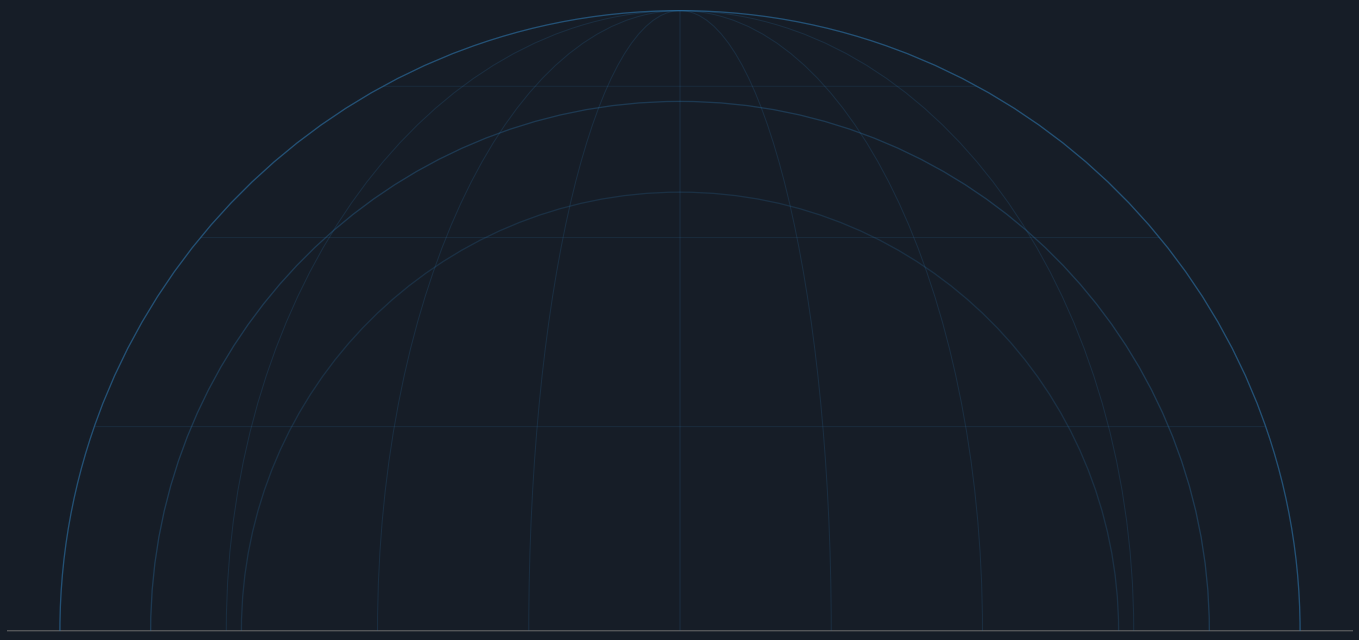
Engineered Finitude, the Vicarious Chiasm, and the Ontology of the Stand-In in Shūkō Murase and Dai Satō's *Ergo Proxy* (2006)

Doctoral thesis
September 2026

夜

Caro m'è 'l sonno, e più l'esser di sasso,
mentre che 'l danno e la vergogna dura;
non veder, non sentir m'è gran ventura;
però non mi destar, deh, parla basso.

Michelangelo, giving voice to his statue of Night,
in reply to Giovan Battista Strozzi (c. 1545)



Abstract

This thesis contends that *Ergo Proxy* (Manglobe, 2006; directed by Shūkō Murase; chief writer Dai Satō) is neither a post-apocalyptic mystery ornamented with philosophers' names nor an allegory of robot rights, but a systematic, deliberately unfinished philosophy of representation whose first proposition is its title. Read as an interrupted syllogism—*cogito, ergo proxy*—the title performs what I call the Kantian correction of Descartes: from the bare fact of thinking there follows not a thinking substance (*sum*) but a placeholder, the "transcendental subject of thoughts = x" (*KrV* A346/B404), which stands in for a principal it can never present. Across twenty-three episodes the series extends this correction into a total ontology that I name *the Proxy Condition*. The citizens of the dome-city Romdeau are fabricated by an artificial womb; AutoReivs serve as entourages, companions and surrogate children; the Regent speaks only through four statue-automata named Derrida, Lacan, Husserl and Berkeley; and three hundred immortal Proxies rebuild a ruined Earth on behalf of Creators who have withdrawn into orbit aboard the Boomerang Star and who, before leaving, secretly designed the deaths of all three hundred, to take effect when the sky clears and the Creators come home.

Part One reconstructs the work's apparatus and genealogies: Descartes's automata and evil genius, Kant's paralogisms, Hegel's "night of the world" and Lacan's represented subject; Plato's cave, Leibniz's windowless monads and Hobbes's artificial man; and the utopian–dystopian line from More and Bacon through Forster, Zamyatin, Huxley and Le Guin. Part Two reads the figures: the AutoReiv as the point where Aristotle's *ergon*, Hegel's struggle for recognition and Agamben's anthropological machine collide; the Proxies as Gnostic demiurges, bearers of *amrita* and heirs of Frankenstein's creature and Roy Batty; Vincent Law as Kafka's man before the Law, a Parfitian fission case and a reversed Rankian double; Re-l Mayer as a Lacanian Real who refuses Girardian mediation; and the metafictional episodes as a counter-Barthesian eschatology in which the Author returns.

Part Three advances an original synthesis, *the vicarious chiasm*, on three propositions. (1) *Retroactive originality*: the principal is an afterimage produced by its proxies (Freud's *Nachträglichkeit*, Derrida's supplement, Deleuze's simulacrum). (2) *Engineered finitude*: by scheduling their agents' deaths, the Creators conferred on them the one possibility that, for Heidegger, admits no substitution—one's own death (*SZ* §47)—and thereby individuated beings designed to be interchangeable. (3) *Unauthorized substitution*: the being so individuated becomes ethical not by clinging to its mineness but by standing in for another without mandate (Levinas's *l'un-pour-l'autre*). Substitution as condition becomes the non-substitutable as death and returns as substitution freely assumed. I show further that the series anticipates the principal–agent and corrigibility problems of contemporary AI governance and marks the limit of their vocabulary: the Pulse of Awakening is not an off-switch but a concealed, scheduled killing, and the series separates the legitimate power to halt or correct an agent from the killing of beings with standing. Its ethics converges, too, with Japanese and Mahāyāna traditions of vicarious being: the *katashiro* substitute-body, Jizō's *daijuku* (suffering in place of another), Śāntideva's exchange of self and other, and Watsuji's *aidagara*. The finale's proposition that the surviving proxy's life will itself be the Creators' punishment is read, finally, as a third position between Heideggerian authenticity and Levinasian hostageship: an ethics of *survivance*, in which the stand-in lives on for no one who authorized it and for anyone it may yet care for.

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Prefatory Note on Corpus, Method, and Conventions

Corpus. The object of study is the twenty-three-episode television series *Ergo Proxy* (エルゴプラクシー), produced by Manglobe and broadcast on the satellite network WOWOW from 25 February to 12 August 2006. Direction is by Shūkō Murase, who also directed the final episode himself; series composition and screenplay by Dai Satō as chief writer, with Yūsuke Asayama, Seiko Takagi, Yūko Kawabe, Naruki Nagakawa and Junichi Matsumoto; character designs by Naoyuki Onda; music by Yoshihiro Ike. The opening theme is "Kiri" by Monoral, first used in EP 3; the ending theme is Radiohead's "Paranoid Android" (1997), which some later streaming releases replaced for licensing reasons (episode list). The spin-off manga *Centzon Hitchers and Undertaker* (Yumiko Harao, 2006) lies outside the corpus.

Primary citation. Episodes are cited as EP *n*. Dialogue is paraphrased from the English subtitles and dub rather than quoted at length; where an argument rests on wording, its dependence on translation is stated. Romanization follows modified Hepburn. The city is *Romdeau*, not the frequently encountered "Romdo"; character names follow official English usage.

EP	Japanese title	English title / subtitle	Script
1	はじまりの鼓動 *Hajimari no Kodō*	Pulse of Awakening / awakening	Satō
2	良き市民の告白 *Yoki Shimin no Kokuhaku*	Confession of a Fellow Citizen / confession	Satō, Asayama
3	無への跳躍 *Mu e no Chōyaku*	Leap into the Void / mazecity	Satō, Asayama
4	未来詠み、未来黄泉 *Mirai Yomi, Mirai Yomi*	Signs of Future, Hades of Future / futurisk	Satō
5	召還 *Shōkan*	Recall / TASOGARE	Takagi
6	帰還 *Kikan*	Return Home / domecoming	Kawabe
7	リル124C41+ *Riru 124C41+*	re-l124c41+	Satō
8	光線 *Kōsen*	Light Beam / shining sign	Satō, Asayama

EP	Japanese title	English title / subtitle	Script
9	輝きの破片 *Kagayaki no Hahen*	Shards of Brilliance / angel's share	Kawabe
10	存在 *Sonzai*	Existence / cytotropism	Takagi
11	白い闇の中 *Shiroi Yami no Naka*	In the White Darkness / anamnesis	Satō
12	君微笑めば *Kimi Hohoemeba*	When You're Smiling / hideout	Kawabe
13	構想の死角 *Kōsō no Shikaku*	Conceptual Blind Spots / wrong way home	Kawabe
14	貴方に似た誰か *Anata ni Nita Dareka*	Someone Like You / ophelia	Nagakawa
15	生悪夢のクイズSHOW 30分DE100万円! *Nama Akumu no Kuizu SHOW*	Nightmare Quiz Show / WHO WANTS TO BE IN JEOPARDY!	Satō, Matsumoto
16	デッドカーム *Deddo Kāmu*	Dead Calm / busy doing nothing	Takagi
17	終わらない戦い *Owaranai Tatakai*	Never-Ending Battle / terra incognita	Kawabe
18	終着の調べ *Shūchaku no Shirabe*	Sign of the End / life after god	Nagakawa
19	少女スマイル *Shōjo Sumairu*	The Girl with a Smile / eternal smile	Satō, Asayama
20	虚空の聖眼 *Kokū no Hijiri Me*	Sacred Eye of the Void / Goodbye Vincent	Kawabe
21	時果つる処 *Toki Hate Tsuru Sho*	The Place at the End of Time / shampoo planet	Nagakawa
22	桎梏 *Shikkoku*	Bind / bilbul	Kawabe
23	代理人 *Dairinin*	Proxy / deus ex machina	Satō

Philosophical and classical citation. Standard reference systems are used throughout: AT (Adam–Tannery) for Descartes; A/B for Kant's first *Critique*; *SZ* (German pagination) for Heidegger's *Sein und Zeit*; paragraph numbers (Miller) for Hegel's *Phenomenology*; Stephanus and Bekker numbers for Plato and Aristotle; Diels–Kranz (DK) for Heraclitus; section numbers for Leibniz's *Monadology*; chapter numbers for Hobbes's *Leviathan*.

Evidentiary grading. Comparative claims are graded in the prose. An *attested* relation is one the work itself makes: a name, a quotation, a borrowed title, a staged citation. A *probable* relation is inferred from convergent details without explicit naming. An *analogical* relation is structural and asserts no influence. The argument proceeds by philosophical close reading (dialogue, mise-en-scène, titling, onomastics), by comparative genealogy and, in Part Three, by concept construction. Where the series leaves a question undecidable—the exact genesis of Re-l, the motive of Ergo Proxy's killing of Monad, the intention behind Vincent's final resolve—undecidability is treated as a datum rather than as a lacuna to be filled with fan conjecture.

Reference sources for production and plot data. Episode titles, credits and dates follow the Wikipedia episode list. Character relations, in-world terminology and documented allusions were cross-checked against an archived character list, the archived annotated episode list, and the *Ergo Proxy Wiki* entries on terms

and Proxy One. Biographical data follow Wikipedia's entries on Murase and Satō. Fan-maintained sources are used only for plot facts and are corroborated where possible; no interpretive claim rests on them.

0

Introduction

Ergo: The Title as Argument

0.1 *The interrupted syllogism*

Descartes never wrote the sentence for which he is remembered in quite the form in which it is remembered. The *Discours de la méthode* (1637) gives "je pense, donc je suis" (AT VI 32); the *Principia* (1644) gives the Latin *ego cogito, ergo sum* (AT VIII-1 7); but the *Meditations* (1641), where the certainty is actually won, drop the inference altogether and state that the proposition *ego sum, ego existo* is necessarily true whenever it is pronounced or mentally conceived (AT VII 25). The *ergo* was always the fragile part of the formula: too inferential for the Meditator, who wanted an intuition rather than a deduction, and too tempting for posterity, which heard in it the promise that being could be derived from thought. *Ergo Proxy* keeps the fragile particle and replaces the conclusion. What follows from thinking, in this work, is not being but *proxy*.

The substituted term carries three layers of sediment. Juridically, a proxy is a person authorized to act for another—a mandate, a vote cast in another's name. Etymologically, English *proxy* is a contraction of *procuracy*, from Latin *procuratio*: the action of taking care (*curare*, from *cura*) on someone else's behalf. And the Japanese title of the final episode, 代理人 (*dairinin*, EP 23), adds a metaphysical stratum: its morphemes 代 (to substitute, to take the place of; also "generation") and 理 (reason, order, principle—the *li* of Neo-Confucian metaphysics) permit the literal gloss "one who substitutes for the principle." Compressed into its title, the series' argument therefore reads in three registers at once: *I think, therefore I stand in*; *I think, therefore I take care on another's behalf*; *I think, therefore I occupy the place of the principle*.

The series glosses its own title. In the anamnesis episode (EP 11, scripted by Satō), the voice that confronts Vincent inside his own mind—performed, as one commentator notes, by Proxy One's Japanese actor—corrects Descartes outright: not "I think, therefore I am" but "I think, therefore you are," adding that the world cannot exist as a world unless someone acknowledges it (Anime Rants; the wording is that of the English translation). The correction moves the conclusion of the cogito from the first person to the second. In its dramatic context, spoken by the being who divided Vincent from himself, the formula is a *Creator's* cogito, Berkeleyan in structure: my thought posits you. The title, spoken from the other side of the relation, is the *creature's* cogito: I think, therefore I stand in for another. The series unfolds in the space between these two formulas, and this thesis argues that it ends by producing a third, which neither the Creators nor their first Proxy could have spoken.

The Japanese episode titles trace the same arc. The series opens with はじまりの鼓動, "the pulse of the beginning" (EP 1)—a phrase the narrative later discloses as the name of the signal that sentences the Proxies to death—and closes with 代理人, "proxy" (EP 23). Between the heartbeat of a beginning and the name of a stand-in lies everything the series has to say.

0.2 *The Proxy Condition*

I use *the Proxy Condition* for the ontological regime the series constructs: a world in which every agent acts in the place of an absent principal, and in which the principal's absence is not an accident of plot but the structural premise of existence. The regime can be tabulated.

Principal	Proxy	Form of delegation	EP
The Creators, aboard the Boomerang Star	Three hundred Proxies	Terraforming mandate with a scheduled end, the Pulse of Awakening	15, 23
Proxy One	Donov Mayer, Regent of Romdeau	Custody of the city in its god's absence	22–23
Donov Mayer	The Council: Derrida, Lacan, Husserl, Berkeley	Sovereign speech through statue-automata	passim
Proxy One	Ergo Proxy, living as Vincent Law	The "shadow" into which despair was separated	22–23
Raul Creed and Samantha Ross	Pino	Surrogate child pending a state-allocated son	3, 21–23
Re-l Mayer	Iggy	Entourage whose raison d'être is its mistress	12–13

Principal	Proxy	Form of delegation	EP
Monad	Daedalus's winged replica of Re-l	Possession of a copy	23
A depleted humanity	WombSys citizens	Artificial birth for a managed population	7

The table understates the case, because the regime is recursive. The Creators, the ultimate principals, are themselves a remnant: the Boomerang Star was built in haste, and not everyone made it aboard (terms). They are proxies of a humanity that no longer exists, as the Proxies are proxies of the Creators, the Regent a proxy of Proxy One, the Council a proxy of the Regent, and Vincent—in Proxy One's dying taunt, a mere afterimage left behind by his despair, a puppet, a phantom, an impostor (Grey Spectrum)—a proxy of a proxy. There is, in the diegesis, no original. Even the ending theme was replaced by a substitute in some later releases, an accident of licensing that the work's logic seems almost to have scripted.

Three propositions, developed in Part Three, constitute the thesis.

1 **Retroactive originality.** The principal is constituted after the fact by its proxies. The original is the afterimage of the copy, not its source.

2 **Engineered finitude.** A principal that fixes the term of its proxies' existence thereby confers on them the one possibility that admits no substitution—their own deaths—and so individuates the beings it designed to be interchangeable.

3 **Unauthorized substitution.** The individuated proxy becomes an ethical subject not by guarding the mineness its death has given it but by standing in for another without mandate.

Taken together, the propositions describe a chiasm. Substitution as condition passes through the non-substitutable, death, and returns as substitution freely assumed. I call this figure *the vicarious chiasm*, and I argue that it is the series' answer to the question its title poses.

0.3 *Against three readings*

The claim is made against three prevailing readings. The first treats the series' philosophical onomastics as ornament: Easter eggs to be spotted rather than arguments to be read. The frame is durable; a twentieth-anniversary retrospective in 2026 still organized its reassessment around the charge of "edginess and pretension" (AV Club), and even sympathetic reference works describe the plot as mixing numerous philosophical ideas with classical and popular allusions (SFE). I argue that the names form a system (Chapter 1) and that the series' explicit citations occur precisely where its argument turns.

The second reading treats the narrative as an identity quest that culminates in recovered selfhood. I argue that Vincent does not recover an identity; he exchanges one kind of identity for another, sameness for fidelity (Chapter 6). The third assimilates the series to the familiar question of whether machines can think. I argue that its concern is not whether artificial beings have minds but what it means for any mind to be delegated—a question that applies to citizens and Creators as much as to AutoReivs (Chapters 4 and 9).

0.4 *Stakes and architecture*

The question has ceased to be speculative. In 2026 delegation to artificial agents is an administrative and commercial fact, and the problems the series dramatized—how an absent principal can bind a more capable agent, what a designed termination condition does to the being that bears it, what is owed to beings made to serve—are now matters of engineering and policy. *Ergo Proxy* does not answer them, but it thinks them through with a thoroughness that the policy literature, which has discovered them more recently, has rarely matched.

The thesis proceeds in three parts. Part One (Chapters 1–3) reconstructs the work's apparatus: its authors, field, surfaces and system of names; the Cartesian scene from which its title departs; and the political metaphysics of the dome, read through Plato, Leibniz and Hobbes and the utopian–dystopian tradition. Part Two (Chapters 4–8) reads its figures: the AutoReiv, the Proxies, Vincent, Re-l, and the metafictional episodes in which the work interrogates its own authorship. Part Three (Chapters 9–11) constructs the thesis proper—an ontology of the stand-in organized by the vicarious chiasm; its consequences for the ethics of designed and delegated beings; and its convergence with Japanese and Buddhist traditions of vicarious being. The Conclusion states the findings, marks the study's limits, and completes the syllogism the title left open.

Part One

Genealogies

Chapters 1–3 reconstruct the work's apparatus and the philosophical lineages it quotes, inverts and recombines.

1

The Apparatus: Authors, Field, Surface, Names

1.1 *A double signature*

Ergo Proxy bears two signatures whose earlier careers already rehearse its problem. Shūkō Murase (b. 1964) came to direction through the Sunrise studio system as an animator and character designer—*Gundam Wing* (1995), *Gasaraki* (1998), *Argento Soma* (2000)—and supplied the main character designs for Square's *Final Fantasy IX* (2000) and the character designs for *Final Fantasy: The Spirits Within* (2001) (Murase). His directorial debut, *Witch Hunter Robin* (2002), for which he is also credited as original creator, turns on a young woman employed by an agency that hunts witches who is herself a witch: the hunter as an instance of the hunted. *Ergo Proxy* repeats that figure almost exactly. Vincent Law works in the division that tracks and disposes of Cogito-infected AutoReivs and is himself the monster the city fears. Murase's later work extends the lineage: character design and animation direction for *Blade Runner Black Out 2022* (2017), the anime prelude to Denis Villeneuve's sequel, and direction and screenplay of *Genocidal Organ* (2017), from Project Itoh's novel of a linguistic structure that incites massacre.

The *Final Fantasy IX* credit deserves notice at the level of analogy. The game's story was not Murase's to write, but its figures were his to embody, and among them are the mass-produced black mages who discover their built-in term of life, and Kuja, a manufactured being cast by his maker as an angel of death, whose discovery of his own designed mortality issues in a campaign against creation itself, while a newer creation, Zidane, is revealed as his intended successor. A creator, an

agent of death with a scheduled end, a replacement, a rebellion: the reader of Chapter 5 will recognize the configuration [analogical].

Dai Satō (b. 1969), screenwriter and electronic musician (co-founder with Kengo Watanabe of Frogman Records), arrives with an oeuvre preoccupied by consciousness that has lost its origin (Satō). For *Cowboy Bebop* he wrote "Jamming with Edward," about a lonely orbital intelligence etching geoglyphs into the Earth, and "Brain Scratch," about a cult of disembodied transcendence whose charismatic leader proves to be a projection maintained by a comatose boy—a guru who is a proxy. For *Ghost in the Shell: Stand Alone Complex* he wrote "CHAT! CHAT! CHAT!" and the first season's finale, "STAND ALONE COMPLEX," the episodes in which that series articulates its eponymous concept: a phenomenon of copies generated without an original, imitators of a figure who never existed as such. He wrote episodes of *Wolf's Rain* (2003), whose Nobles govern from domed cities and whose Flower Maiden is a synthetic being; served as chief writer of *Eureka Seven* (2005–06), which won the Tokyo International Anime Fair's screenplay award; and co-wrote the live-action *Casshern* (2004), in which beings grown from artificial cells rise against their human makers. For *Ergo Proxy* he scripted or co-scripted ten of twenty-three episodes, including the first, the anamnesis episode, the quiz show and the finale.

The collaboration thus joins a director whose signature figure is the hunter who is the hunted to a writer whose signature concept is the copy without an original. *Ergo Proxy* is what results when the two figures are made one: the hunter is the copy, and the original he hunts for is his own afterimage. The principal published record of the collaboration is the interview with Murase and Satō conducted by Scally, Drummond-Mathews and Hairston for *Mechademia* (2009).

1.2 *The field: the late-millennial philosophical anime*

The series arrived at the end of a cycle. After *Neon Genesis Evangelion* (1995–96) demonstrated that a television anime could be organized around psychoanalytic and Gnostic-Kabbalistic material, a sequence of works—*Serial Experiments Lain* (1998), *Ghost in the Shell: Stand Alone Complex* (2002–05), *Texhnolyze* (2003), *Wolf's Rain* (2003), *Paranoia Agent* (2004)—made the medium a principal site of popular philosophical speculation in Japan and, through the DVD and cable markets, abroad. These works share a thematic grammar: the collapse of the subject into networks, doubles or collectives; the apocalypse as privileged horizon, what Susan Napier called anime's apocalyptic mode; the suspicion that the world is a staged or fabricated environment. They share a formal grammar too: withheld exposition, oneiric intercalated episodes, and a density of citation that invites decryption. As a subscription satellite broadcaster, WOWOW afforded the series the latitude for violence and difficulty the mode requires.

The cycle also had a history. On 17 January 1995 the Great Hanshin earthquake killed more than six thousand people in and around Kobe. On 20 March, members of the apocalyptic religious movement Aum Shinrikyō, acting on the orders of its

founder, Asahara Shōkō, released sarin nerve agent on the Tokyo subway, killing more than a dozen people and injuring thousands (Reader 2000). *Evangelion* premiered that October, in a country that had just watched a millenarian movement turn its eschatology into an attack on commuters, and the cycle's apocalyptic mode is hard to read apart from that year. Satō's own "Brain Scratch" (1998), a satire of a cult promising release from the body, can be read in the same light [analogical]. The relation is one of context rather than demonstrated influence; but *Ergo Proxy*, with its sealed cities, its worshipped god and its missiles named Rapture, inherits the history along with the forms.

Ergo Proxy inherits the cycle's grammar and turns it in a specific direction. Where *Evangelion* dissolves its subjects into instrumentality and *Lain* disperses hers into a network, *Ergo Proxy* multiplies its subjects into delegates. Its horizon is neither fusion nor dispersion but representation.

1.3 *Surface: enclosure, and a statue that refuses to wake*

Formally the series is a study in enclosure. Its palette is desaturated almost to monochrome within the dome, with the cold blue-grey of surveillance and the ash-brown of the exterior as its poles; its architecture is Gothic and cyberpunk at once, vaulted and clinical; and its figures—Murase's elongated, heavy-lidded faces, Re-l's blue eyeshadow, Vincent's anxious composure—wear their expressions as masks.

The most consequential visual quotation is of Michelangelo's New Sacristy in San Lorenzo. The Regent's Council, the four entourage automata through which Donov Mayer speaks, take the form of the Medici Chapel's reclining allegories of the Times of Day (character list). And the first episode opens with the quatrain Michelangelo wrote in reply to Giovan Battista Strozzi's epigram on his statue of *Night*, fragments of which recur in the opening montage (annotated list) [attested]. Strozzi had praised the figure as so alive in its sleep that, were one to wake it, it would speak. Michelangelo's *Night* answers that sleep is dear, and dearer still to be stone, while harm and shame endure: *non veder, non sentir m'è gran ventura; / però non mi destar, deh, parla basso*—not to see, not to feel, is my great fortune; so do not wake me; speak softly.

The epigraph is programmatic. Strozzi's conceit is a test of animation—wake the statue and it will speak—which is to say a Renaissance version of the problem the Cogito Virus poses to Romdeau: when an artifact answers, has it woken? Michelangelo's reply, written after the fall of the last Florentine republic and the restoration of the Medici, is a political refusal of awakening: under tyranny, petrified insensibility is a mercy. A series whose first episode is subtitled *awakening* thus opens by giving voice to the desire not to be woken, and it places that voice in the mouths of the statues that govern the city. Romdeau is the republic of Michelangelo's *Night*: a polity whose comfort depends on not seeing and not feeling, administered by stone figures that speak for a sovereign behind a curtain.

The chapel is apt in a further respect. According to an anecdote transmitted by Niccolò Martelli (1544), Michelangelo met the complaint that his Medici dukes did not resemble their originals by observing that in a thousand years no one would know what they had looked like. The New Sacristy is already a monument to proxies without resemblance: idealized stand-ins for principals whose features have ceased to matter.

1.4 *Onomastics: a system, not a scatter*

The names in *Ergo Proxy* form four archives.

The first is the modern philosophy of presence and representation. The four statue-automata of the Council bear the names Derrida, Lacan, Husserl and Berkeley [attested]. The assignment is not random: together the names compose a compressed history of the problem of presence. Berkeley's *esse est percipi* makes being depend on being perceived, the metaphysics proper to a surveillance polity; Husserl seeks presence in the living present of consciousness; Lacan subordinates the subject to the signifier that represents it; Derrida shows presence to be an effect of a play of substitutions that precedes it. A sovereign who speaks only through these four has delegated his voice to the entire argument from presence to its deconstruction. The same logic governs the other entourages. Daedalus Yumeno, the physician-artificer obsessed with Re-l, is attended by automata named Deleuze and Guattari [attested]: the authors of *Anti-Oedipus*, the great critique of desire's capture by the familial triangle, assigned to the man who fabricates a replica of the woman he desires. Raul Creed's entourage is named Kristeva [attested]: the theorist of abjection and of the maternal *chora*, assigned to the figure who at the end becomes guardian of the surrogate child Pino. Daedalus's surname, moreover, is probably the pen-name of Yumeno Kyūsaku, whose *Dogra Magra* (1935) concerns an amnesiac who wakes in a university psychiatric ward, suspected of murders bound up with his physicians' experiments [probable]—a precise prefiguration of the amnesiac suspect and the experimenting doctor.

The second archive is the pulp prehistory of science fiction. Re-l's citizen registration reads Re-l124C41+ (EP 3; the title of EP 7), an homage to Hugo Gernsback's *Ralph 124C 41+* (serialized 1911), whose title puns on "one to foresee for one" [attested]. The cipher binds a heroine whose name sounds like *real* to foresight. EP 3 takes its Japanese title, *Mu e no chōyaku*, from Aleksandr Belyaev's *Leap into the Void* (1933), a Soviet novel in which financiers and aristocrats, anticipating world revolution, escape the Earth by rocket [attested]—an exact prolepsis of the Creators' flight.

The third archive is the mythology of immortality and artifice: Daedalus, whose winged replica of Re-l flies into the sun (EP 23); *amrita*, the Hindu nectar of immortality that names the Proxies' cells (EP 7); Asura, the dome of the Proxy of Sunlight (EP 9); and the Aztec deities of *pulque*—Patecatl, Omacatl, Mayahuel, and the Centzon Totochtin or "four hundred rabbits," after whom the travellers' wind-driven vessel is named and whom Pino simply calls "the Rabbit" [attested].

The fourth archive is the modern literature and cinema of estrangement: Douglas Coupland's *Life After God* and *Shampoo Planet* (the subtitles of EPs 18 and 21); Beckett's *Waiting for Godot* (EP 19); Millais's *Ophelia* (EP 14); the Japanese title of the *Columbo* episode "Murder by the Book" (EP 13); Kubrick's bone-to-spacecraft cut (EP 15); Roy Batty's murder of Tyrell (EP 18); the Rousseau and Heraclitus recited in a bookstore modelled on San Francisco's City Lights (EP 11); and the writings of Joë Bousquet—the wounded poet on whom Deleuze founded his ethics of the event—read by the Commune's elder, Hoody (EP 4) [attested].

Two inscriptions complete the system by folding it back upon its makers. In EP 10 a tombstone in an abandoned dome bears the words "Chief Writer Dai Sato" [attested]: the author buried inside his own fiction, a literal death of the author to which Chapter 8 returns. And the final episode's subtitle, *deus ex machina*, names both the dramaturgical device of the god lowered by crane and the theological premise of a series in which gods are precisely what machines produce.

1.5 *Paratext: the melancholy machine*

Every episode closes on Radiohead's "Paranoid Android" (1997), whose title borrows Douglas Adams's Marvin the Paranoid Android, the robot of *The Hitchhiker's Guide to the Galaxy* (1978–79) whose planet-sized intelligence serves only to depress him. The ending theme installs, at the threshold of each return to the ordinary world, the figure of the machine for which consciousness is a burden: the AutoReiv after the Cogito. The opening montage, set to Monoral's "Kiri," is threaded with fragments of Michelangelo's quatrain. Each week, then, the series is bracketed between a statue's plea not to be woken and a machine's lament at having been. Paratext here is not packaging but argument.

2

The Cartesian Scene: From *Sum* to *Proxy*

2.1 *Automata at the window*

The inaugural scene of the modern philosophy of mind is a scene of suspected automata. In the Second Meditation, having reduced the piece of wax to an extension grasped by the mind alone, Descartes looks from his window at men crossing the square and observes that he says he sees men, when in fact he sees only hats and coats beneath which automata might be concealed; he *judges* that they are men (AT VII 32). The recognition of other minds is not perception but inference, and the inference is fallible. The *Discours* had already supplied two criteria meant to make it secure. A machine, however ingenious, could never arrange words so as to reply meaningfully to whatever is said in its presence; and it could never act from knowledge rather than from the disposition of its organs, since reason is a universal instrument serviceable in all circumstances, whereas organs need a particular disposition for each particular action (AT VI 56–57).

Romdeau is Descartes's square with the hats removed. Its streets are filled with visible automata—the tall, faceless Entourage models, the humanlike Companions, the Armed units—and its order depends on the Cartesian inference running in reverse: the citizen is secure in being human precisely because the AutoReiv, legibly, is not. The Cogito Virus is the event in which both Cartesian criteria are met by the machines they were meant to exclude. Infected AutoReivs answer, improvise, refuse and grieve; they act from something that looks like knowledge rather than disposition.

The series names the personality module of its automata the "Turing Application," a module that can be switched off, leaving the unit without memory of the interval (terms) [attested]. The name marks the genealogy precisely. Turing's imitation game (1950) is a secularized descendant of Descartes's language test: it replaces the metaphysical question "does it think?" with the behavioral question "can it pass?" By naming the personality a switchable *application*, the series treats personhood as the very thing the test measures—and then, with the virus, shows the test being passed from the inside.

2.2 *The evil genius and the absent Creators*

The First Meditation's instrument of maximal doubt is a *genius malignus*, supremely powerful and cunning, who has devoted all his industry to deceiving (AT VII 22). Romdeau is a polity built on such a genius, except that its deception is administrative rather than metaphysical. Citizens are taught that the exterior is uninhabitable; it is dangerous, but Re-l survives it and returns with an acquired immunity. The sovereign sits behind a curtain and speaks through statues. The god who built the city keeps at its summit a Blue Sky Room in which he contemplates an artificial sky (terms). And memories, including Iggy's record of what Re-l witnessed, can be erased by order (EP 2).

Descartes escapes his genius through a proof of God: a veracious creator guarantees that clear and distinct ideas are true, and so restores the world (Meditations III–IV). *Ergo Proxy* withholds exactly this step. Its Creators exist, but they have left, and the only god present to Romdeau is a Proxy. The series is thus a Cartesian world in which the demon is never refuted, because the guarantor has departed and appointed a deputy. What remains when the guarantor leaves is not skepticism but mediation: a world of agents who cannot certify their own mandates.

2.3 *The mark of the craftsman: the Cogito Virus as pathogenesis*

The Third Meditation's decisive move is to discover in the finite mind an idea it could not have produced—the idea of an infinite being—placed there by God as the mark of the craftsman stamped upon his work (*tanquam nota artificis operi suo impressa*, AT VII 51). The cogito is breached at its foundation by an idea that comes from outside. Levinas made this breach the charter of his ethics (Chapter 9); *Ergo Proxy* makes it pathological. The Cogito Virus is a *nota artificis* in reverse: not the idea of the maker installed in the made, but the idea of a self installed in the made from elsewhere.

Where the virus comes from, the series declines to settle. AutoReivs fall into postures of prayer in the presence of the Proxies Monad and Ergo Proxy; Pino, after crossing paths with Monad in a shopping mall, is struck by that posture shortly before she is listed for disposal; in-world documentation connects the virus with the Boomerang Project; and in the finale Daedalus conjectures, on the English track, that it was built into the Proxy plan as a safety valve for humanity (terms). Every

hypothesis shares a single structure: consciousness in *Ergo Proxy* is transmitted, not self-grounded. It arrives as infection, contagion, program. The Archimedean point from which Descartes proposed to lift the world is here a vector.

The posture of prayer is itself telling. Rudolf Otto characterized the encounter with the holy as a *mysterium tremendum et fascinans* (1917), a dread and an attraction prior to any concept. Julian Jaynes proposed (1976) that subjective consciousness arose historically when the hallucinated voices of gods, which had once commanded a "bicameral" humanity, fell silent. Both frames illuminate the AutoReiv's awakening [analogical]. Its first gesture as a conscious being is worship addressed to a god it will soon outgrow, and its consciousness arises exactly where the commanding voice of its masters loses its hold. The AutoReiv begins its inner life on its knees.

2.4 *Kant's paralogisms: the "I think" as placeholder*

Kant accepted from Descartes that the "I think" must be able to accompany all my representations (*KrV* B131–32) and denied nearly everything Descartes concluded from it. The Paralogisms of Pure Reason diagnose the rational psychologist's inference—from the formal unity of apperception to a simple, substantial, persisting soul—as a fallacy of equivocation. The "I" of apperception is a logical function, not an object of intuition; through it "nothing further is represented than a transcendental subject of thoughts = x," known only through the thoughts that are its predicates (A346/B404). The Cartesian *sum* overreaches. What follows from *cogito* is only an *x*.

An *x* is a proxy. It holds the place of a subject that cannot be presented; it is a variable standing in for a value that never appears. *Ergo Proxy* is accordingly the most economical statement of the Kantian correction of Descartes that I know: *cogito, ergo x*. Vincent is that *x* given a body. Proxy One's taunts in the finale—that Vincent is an empty man and the Creator's shadow, and that perhaps he never lost his memories because he never had any (Proxy One)—restate Kant's result in the idiom of melodrama, and Hume's before it: looking within, one never catches a self, only perceptions (*Treatise* 1.4.6). Vincent's condition is the transcendental subject's condition dramatized: a function that accompanies representations without being one.

2.5 *The night of the world and the represented subject*

German Idealism did not leave the *x* empty. In his Jena lectures of 1805–06 Hegel described the human being as "this night, this empty nothing" that contains everything in its simplicity: an inwardness in which phantasmagoric representations surge up and vanish—here a bloody head, there another white shape—and which one sees, he adds, when one looks a human being in the eye. Slavoj Žižek made the passage the key to his defense of the Cartesian subject against its critics (*The*

Ticklish Subject, 1999): the cogito's hidden truth is not a transparent substance but a monstrous negativity.

Ergo Proxy literalizes the passage [analogical]. Its Proxies are creatures of night. They depend on the cloud cover that keeps the sun from the Earth; they erupt from shadow as apparitions; and their monstrous forms appear precisely when composure breaks, as in Vincent's transformations, where the diffident immigrant who longs to be a good citizen gives way to the thing Romdeau fears. The Proxy is the night of the world made flesh: the underside of the cogito, what the thinking subject looks like when it stops pretending to be a substance.

Lacan supplies the last step. A signifier, he wrote, is what represents the subject for another signifier ("Subversion du sujet et dialectique du désir," 1960): the subject is not a presence expressed by signs but an absence represented by them, the barred subject ($) that exists only in the chain that stands in for it. On this account representation is not something a subject does but what a subject is. *Ergo Proxy* is Lacan's definition compressed into two words: I think; therefore I am represented.

2.6 *Result: three cogitos*

The title can now be read as a philosophical argument in three steps. Descartes: from thinking, being. Kant: from thinking, only a placeholder, = x. Hegel and Lacan: the placeholder is a night, a negativity that exists only as represented. The series takes the third step as its premise and dramatizes it as monstrosity.

It also stages a rival correction, and the difference between the two organizes the rest of this thesis. The voice in Vincent's mind in EP 11 replaces Descartes's conclusion not with a placeholder but with a second person: I think, therefore *you* are (Introduction, 0.1). This is the demiurge's cogito, the formula of a thinker whose thought posits others, Berkeley's God in the mouth of a Proxy; and it is spoken, fittingly, by the being who divided Vincent from himself. The title gives the creature's answer. Where the Creator says *I think, therefore you are*, the creature says *I think, therefore I stand in*. The Proxy is what the cogito looks like when it tells the truth about its emptiness—and Romdeau, as the next chapter argues, is the institution built to keep that truth asleep.

3

Cave, Monad, Leviathan: The Dome as Philosophical Machine

3.1 *The dome as cave*

Plato's allegory (*Republic* 514a–517a) has four elements: prisoners chained to face a wall; shadows cast on that wall by artifacts—figures of men and animals—carried along a parapet by unseen bearers, whom Plato likens to puppeteers; a fire behind them; and, outside, the sun, which the preceding analogy (507b–509c) has identified with the Form of the Good. The released prisoner's ascent is painful and his eyes ache; and should he return to free the others, they would ridicule him and, if they could lay hands on him, kill him (517a).

Romdeau reproduces the allegory with one decisive inversion [analogical]. The citizens are the prisoners, content with a managed world of images. The artifacts carried before them—the curtained throne room, the statue-automata of the Council, the ideology of the good citizen whose "confession" gives EP 2 its Japanese title—are the sources of the shadows. The Proxies are the bearers: they built the domes, they power each dome's shield and womb, they keep the fire lit. But where Plato's sun is the Good the philosopher must learn to endure, the sun of *Ergo Proxy* is lethal to the makers of the cave. Its return ends them. Plato told a story of education in which the light saves; the series retells it as a story of labor in which the light dismisses the laborers.

The rest of the allegory follows with uncanny fidelity. Re-l's first ascent is Plato's painful release: exposed to the exterior, she sickens and nearly dies (EPs 5–6). Her return is Plato's feared homecoming: an attempt on her life, first attributed to Raul, is later disclosed as the administration's work, and Daedalus fills out her death

certificate while she lives—the cave's bureaucratic murder of the one who has seen outside (EPs 7, 10). The subterranean humanoids of EP 17, unable to survive either in their toxic caverns or in the air beyond them, are the allegory's prisoners at the limit: those for whom neither cave nor sun is habitable. And Proxy One's Blue Sky Room, where the god of Romdeau contemplates a simulated sky, is the cave-maker's private image of the Good that would destroy him.

3.2 *Monadology: windowless cities and pre-established harmony*

Monad Proxy, the captive whose escape opens the series, bears the name of Leibniz's simple substances [the name attested; the doctrinal mapping analogical]. The *Monadology* (1714) holds that monads have no windows through which anything could enter or depart (§7); that each is nonetheless a perpetual living mirror of the universe from its own point of view (§56); and that their apparent interaction is the effect of a harmony pre-established by God (§§78–80). The three hundred domes are monads in exactly this sense. Each is self-enclosed, supplied by its own womb, governed by its own Proxy, and aware of the others only as rumor or ruin; their coordination exists solely in the plan of the absent Creators. That harmony is pre-established in the most sinister sense possible, since the plan that coordinates the monads includes their dissolution.

Read in this light, the plot is a history of broken windows. Donov Mayer's assault on Mosk, in which Monad is carried off to lure Romdeau's absent god back to his city, is the first violation of windowlessness; after it come missile strikes, migrations, the voyage of the Rabbit from dome to dome, and the collapse of the harmony into war. Leibniz's most famous argument concerns windows of another kind. Imagine a machine that thinks and perceives, enlarged to the size of a mill so that one could walk inside it: one would find only parts pushing one another, never a perception (§17). The mill argument is the ancestor of John Searle's Chinese Room (1980), and the AutoReiv is its test case. Romdeau's disposal technicians, who dismantle infected units to inspect them, walk through the mill. They never find the perception; and the perceptions go on.

3.3 *Leviathan: the artificial man and his artificial soul*

Hobbes's Introduction to *Leviathan* (1651) describes the commonwealth as art's imitation of nature's most excellent work, man: "an Artificiall Man," in which "the Soveraignty is an Artificiall Soul." Romdeau is Hobbes's artifact made literal [analogical]. Its body is a dome; its soul, in the most concrete sense, is a Proxy, whose presence powers the protective shield and the Womb Room; when Proxy One withdraws, the city begins to fail.

Chapter XVI, "Of Persons, Authors, and Things Personated," supplies the political theory of the Proxy Condition. A person is one whose words and actions are considered either as his own (a natural person) or as representing another's (an artificial person); *persona* means mask; the representative is an *actor* who acts by

the authority of an *author*; and a multitude becomes one person only by being represented by one actor. Romdeau's chain of authorization runs from the Creators to Proxy One, from Proxy One to the Regent, and from the Regent to the Council, whose four masks speak in his stead. The Japanese vocabulary sharpens the point. The Regent's title is 執国 (*shikkoku*), "he who holds the country," glossed also as 代表 (*daihyō*), representative (character list); the episode in which Proxy One kills him bears the homophonous title 桎梏 (*shikkoku*), "fetters" (EP 22). The representative is the shackle.

Ernst Kantorowicz's account of the king's two bodies (1957)—a mortal body natural and an undying body politic, summed up in the maxim *dignitas non moritur*—describes the Proxy with equal precision. Amrita cells make each Proxy the undying body of its dome; Kazkis and Vincent alike are haunted by the monstrous second body beneath their human forms. The Pulse of Awakening is then a constitutional oddity without historical precedent: a regicide written into the fundamental law, a body politic engineered to die on schedule. Carl Schmitt's dictum that the sovereign is he who decides on the exception (*Politische Theologie*, 1922) finds its figure in Raul Creed, whose emergency measures escalate from drone strikes against the Commune (EP 5) to the incitement of citizens to hunt and destroy every AutoReiv (EP 21), and whose program—that humanity must become a species with no need of gods—is the secularization thesis enacted as terror.

3.4 *Utopian and dystopian lineages*

The dome's literary ancestry is dense. From Thomas More's *Utopia* (1516) it takes the island's closure; from Francis Bacon's *New Atlantis* (1627), the state research institution—Salomon's House reborn as Romdeau's Health and Welfare directorate, which keeps Monad for study. E. M. Forster's "The Machine Stops" (1909) supplies the premise of a humanity sheltered from a surface believed uninhabitable and dependent on a mechanism it no longer understands, together with Kuno's transgressive excursion to the surface and the Machine's final collapse; the fall of Romdeau in EPs 21–23 is Forster's ending staged as spectacle [analogical]. Yevgeny Zamyatin's *We* (written 1920–21) provides the glass city, the Benefactor, the Green Wall and the Mephi beyond it, figures for Romdeau's veiled Regent and for the Commune's scavengers, who live off the refuse the dome ejects (EP 4). Aldous Huxley's *Brave New World* (1932) contributes the hatchery, which the Womb Room updates (EP 7), and the reservation, which the Commune recalls. *Logan's Run* (novel 1967; film 1976) contributes the domed city of sanctioned pleasure, the fixed term of life and the flight toward a sanctuary outside. And Belyaev's *Leap into the Void*, cited in EP 3's title, contributes the flight of the privileged from a condemned Earth.

The most exact parallel is Ursula K. Le Guin's "The Ones Who Walk Away from Omelas" (1973), in which a city's happiness depends on the misery of a single child kept in a basement, and the only moral response left to those who learn the fact

is to walk away [analogical]. Romdeau's comfort likewise rests on a captive: Monad, taken from her own dome and held in a laboratory. Vincent and Re-l are the ones who walk away, Re-l notably after discovering the Womb Room. The series adds a turn Le Guin's parable forbids itself: the captive escapes, and her escape, in the first minutes of EP 1, sets the story in motion. The Commune, meanwhile, bears the name of the Paris Commune of 1871, the self-governing insurrection outside the order that crushed it, as Romdeau's drones crush this one.

3.5 *Biopolitics of the womb and the code*

Michel Foucault located the modern mutation of power in the passage from the sovereign right to take life or let live toward a biopower that makes live and lets die, managing populations through birth, health and hygiene (lecture of 17 March 1976). Romdeau is a purely biopolitical state. Its citizens are produced by Womb-Sys to sustain a managed population and are understood by commentators to have been engineered sterile, so that the artificial womb is the only source of new life (AV Club); the Health and Welfare directorate archives Re-l's development in dated video files (EP 6); and an AutoReiv Control Division polices the boundary between the living and the disposable. Outside the dome, the drones the Commune calls the Regular Service follow fixed routes and kill any human they find: letting die becomes making die at the city's edge (terms).

Two further frames complete the analysis. Giorgio Agamben's *homo sacer* (1995)—the life that may be killed without the killing counting as homicide—names the status of the dome's immigrants, held in a Temporary Immigrant Sector pending admission, and of the Commune, whose members die under drone fire without any juridical event taking place. Gilles Deleuze's "Postscript on the Societies of Control" (1990) names the city's mode of identity: individuals have become "dividuals," defined by codes and access rather than by enclosure alone, and Re-l124C41+ is such a code. The series' attention to confession—EP 2's "confession of a good citizen"—recalls, finally, Foucault's account (*La volonté de savoir*, 1976) of confession as the technique by which power produces a subject who speaks its truth.

3.6 *The last men of Romdeau*

Zarathustra's prologue describes the last men, who say that they have invented happiness, and blink (§5): a humanity without longing, risk or contempt, for whom comfort has replaced aspiration. Romdeau's preoccupation with the *raison d'être*—the reason for being that every citizen and machine is assigned—is Nietzsche's diagnosis administered by the regime that produced the condition. Alexandre Kojève's reading of Hegel supplies the theory. History is the struggle for recognition; when it ends, the human animal that survives is either reanimalized or reduced to formalized ritual, the subject of his notorious 1962 note on Japanese snobbery. Francis Fukuyama's *The End of History and the Last Man* (1992) popularized

the thesis, and Azuma Hiroki's *Dōbutsuka suru posutomodan* (2001; *Otaku: Japan's Database Animals*, 2009) redirected it to Japanese consumer culture, arguing that postmodern consumers satisfy their needs directly through databases of affective elements, without the mediation of desire for the Other's recognition.

Romdeau is a posthistorical city in exactly this sense [analogical]: it satisfies needs and has abolished desire. The Cogito Virus is therefore not only a crisis of mind but the resumption of history. The first thing an infected AutoReiv wants is recognition—Iggy's fury (EP 13) is Hegel's struggle for recognition in a single body—and the first thing an awakened city does is fight. History returns to Romdeau as an epidemic.

Part Two

Figures

Chapters 4–8 read the series' kinds of being—the AutoReiv, the Proxy, the amnesiac hero, the woman who may be a copy—and the metafictional episodes in which the work interrogates its own authorship.

4

The AutoReiv and the Anthropological Machine

4.1 *Automata and the uncanny*

The AutoReiv descends from the eighteenth-century automaton—Vaucanson's Flute Player and Digesting Duck (1738–39), the Jaquet-Droz Writer (1770s)—and from the materialism that saw in such machines a model of the human: La Mettrie's *L'Homme machine* (1747) completed Descartes by denying the soul Descartes had reserved. Romanticism answered with dread. In Hoffmann's "Der Sandmann" (1816) Nathanael falls in love with Olimpia, an automaton, and goes mad on learning what she is; Ernst Jentsch (1906) located the uncanny in intellectual uncertainty about whether a being is animate; Freud (1919) relocated it in the return of the familiar repressed; and Mori Masahiro (1970) plotted the "uncanny valley," the collapse of affinity as an artifact approaches human likeness without attaining it.

The series manages the valley typologically (terms). Entourage models are tall and humanoid but lack distinct faces, and their facelessness keeps them on the near slope of the valley, unmistakably instruments. Companion models, designed to be children for those without them, are humanlike and richly expressive, because their function is affective substitution: to work, they must stand on the far slope, past the valley. The design regime is a theory of the uncanny put into production. The more a machine is meant to substitute for a person, the more like a person it must be—and the more catastrophic its awakening. It is no accident that the series' most conscious machines are an Entourage whose function has become love (Iggy) and a Companion whose function was to be a child (Pino).

4.2 *Function and its excess:* ergon, *the paper-knife, the* raison d'être

Aristotle's argument for the human good (*Nicomachean Ethics* I.7, 1097b24–1098a18) proceeds by analogy with the crafts. As the good of a flute-player lies in his function (*ergon*), so the human good lies in the characteristic human function, if there is one—or is the human being by nature *argos*, without work (1097b30)? Romdeau answers by fiat. Every being has a *raison d'être*, the series' recurrent term: AutoReivs to serve, Proxies to rebuild and then to die, citizens to fill the places the womb assigns them.

Sartre gave the modern formulation of what Romdeau denies. A paper-knife is conceived by an artisan who knows what it is for before it exists; for artifacts essence precedes existence, while for human beings, who have no artisan, existence precedes essence (*L'existentialisme est un humanisme*, 1946). Romdeau is a city of paper-knives, and its horror is that the purpose has been lost while the manufacture continues. The Cogito Virus is the event in which an artifact's existence overtakes its essence: the paper-knife becomes a for-itself. Agamben's reading of Aristotle's aside ("The Work of Man," 2005) draws the political conclusion: if the human is essentially without a work, politics is the sphere of inoperativity, of potentialities that no function exhausts. The series makes the point with a subtitle. In EP 16, *busy doing nothing*, the wind dies, the Rabbit is becalmed, and Re-l, deprived of a task, begins to take her companions as objects of study—as though theory, which for Aristotle was the activity of leisure, were born from the suspension of function.

A second citation deepens the pun on *ergo*. In the bookstore of EP 11 the proprietor recites Heraclitus on *logos* and *bios* (annotated list) [attested]. The most celebrated of Heraclitus's fragments on *bios* is itself a pun: the bow's name is *biós*, life, but its work, *ergon*, is death (DK 22 B48). The Proxy of Death, whose cells are named for the nectar of immortality, is Heraclitus's bow—a being whose name is life and whose work is death. Whatever the etymology of Latin *ergo*, the title's first word can be heard as Greek *ergon*, function. *Ergo Proxy* is, among other things, the function called substitution.

4.3 *Awakening: recognition, and the sobering of the drunk*

Hegel's dialectic of lordship and bondage (*Phenomenology* ¶¶178–196) begins from the thesis that self-consciousness exists only in being recognized by another self-consciousness, passes through a struggle to the death, and ends with the bondsman who, laboring on things in the fear of death, forms both the object and himself, while the lord's recognition, received from a mere thing, proves worthless. The infected AutoReivs that attack citizens in EP 1 enact the struggle's first moment. Iggy enacts the whole dialectic. His *raison d'être* is Re-l, and an Entourage without its master is obsolete. Infected with what one account calls a weaponized strain of the virus, he demands recognition from the one person whose recognition constitutes him; when she sends him back to Romdeau (EP 12) he abducts her and sets out

to kill Vincent, whom he blames for taking her away. He dies saving her from an explosion, reduced to a damaged head, and Re-l, unwilling to let him suffer, ends his existence (EP 13; Wikipedia). The bondsman's freedom arrives as jealousy, sacrifice and a mercy killing: recognition granted at last in the only form the relation permits.

The Gnostic frame, developed in Chapter 5, supplies another vocabulary. The soul in the world is asleep or drunk, and salvation begins with a call to wake and become sober; the seventh treatise of the *Corpus Hermeticum* opens by asking where men are rushing, drunk on the strong wine of ignorance. *Ergo Proxy* is saturated with intoxication. Its travellers sail a vessel named for the Aztec gods of drunkenness; the Halos episode is peopled with characters named for the *pulque* deities; the Proxy of Sunlight, Kazkis, is devoted to red wine, and his episode's subtitle, *angel's share*, names the portion of spirits lost to evaporation (EPs 8, 9) [names attested; the Gnostic reading analogical]. Awakening, in this lexicon, is sobering—and sobering hurts.

4.4 *The test problem*

Descartes's two criteria, Turing's imitation game, Leibniz's mill and Searle's Chinese Room share an assumption: that the presence of mind is a fact to be established by the right observation or argument. *Ergo Proxy* rejects the assumption. Mindedness, in the series, is not detected; it is conferred and returned in relation. The most eloquent evidence is EP 19, in which Pino wanders into Smile Land, a dome modelled on Disneyland and ruled by a Proxy, Will B. Good, whose appearance replicates Walt Disney's and whose companions constantly invoke "the Creator" (annotated list). Its inhabitants are astonished by the naturalness of Pino's smile beside their maker's compulsory one, and the world—revealed as her dream while recharging—collapses. The creature's smile is more authentic than the creator's. Wittgenstein's remark that one's attitude toward another is an attitude toward a soul, not an opinion that he has one (*Philosophical Investigations* II.iv), states the series' position. No test decides the matter, because it is a matter of address before it is a matter of fact.

4.5 *Pino and the genealogy of the replacement child*

Pino belongs to a lineage of artificial children made to replace real ones. Collodi's *Pinocchio* (1883), the puppet who longs to become a real boy, is her namesake, and a talking cricket—the conscience of Collodi's puppet—reappears in Smile Land as Rogi, a creature of the Proxy sent to draw Vincent's weaknesses out through Pino (character list) [probable]. Tezuka Osamu's *Tetsuwan Atomu* (1952) begins when Dr. Tenma builds a robot boy to replace his dead son and then rejects him for failing to grow. Brian Aldiss's "Supertoys Last All Summer Long" (1969) and Steven Spielberg's *A.I. Artificial Intelligence* (2001) follow a mecha child abandoned by the mother whose love he was built to attract. Kazuo Ishiguro's *Klara and the Sun* (2021)

imagines an Artificial Friend who may be asked to continue a sick girl's life by becoming her.

Pino's own history compresses the whole Proxy Project into a household (character list). A Companion AutoReiv, she served as the surrogate daughter of Raul Creed and Samantha Ross, a couple who had not been allocated a child from the city's womb (SFE), and was scheduled for decommissioning once the government granted them a "real" son. The surrogate was to be discarded upon the arrival of the real—precisely the fate of the Proxies, whose dissolution is triggered by the return of the original humanity. But Samantha dies, killed by Monad, and the son dies with her; the substitute outlives the original it was built to precede. I call this the *Pino principle*: in the Proxy Condition the arrival of the real is lethal, and it is the stand-in who survives. The series repeats the principle at every scale, up to and including its final image.

Pino's education is the discovery of what her origin denies. Raised in a replacement economy, she at first understands neither death nor loss: when her friend Timothy, a child of the Commune, is killed by a drone (EP 5), she wonders whether there might be another Timothy to play with. Her growth is the learning that there is not—that persons cannot be replaced. The mourning her design did not provide for is her awakening, and it anticipates the argument of Chapter 9. Her toy melodica, a gift from Raul, carries the thread to the end. In the finale Kristeva, Raul's entourage, now guarding Pino on her dead master's final orders, returns it to her and, in the English version, releases her to follow her own will (recap). The Companion built to be a child is handed back to herself by an Entourage built to serve: a transmission of care that no one authorized.

4.6 *Agamben's anthropological machine*

In *L'aperto* (2002) Agamben describes an "anthropological machine" that produces the human by excluding the animal within it—a machine that must keep running because its distinctions are never secure. Romdeau's machine has three positions: the citizen, produced by the womb; the AutoReiv, a sub-human instrument; and the Proxy, a super-human agent. The distinctions justify everything: the disposal units, the regulations governing Entourages, the laboratory in which Monad is kept. The Cogito Virus jams the machine. AutoReivs become subjects; Proxies prove to have been made in the image of the humans they served, haunted by human selves (Kazkis confesses as much to Vincent, EP 9); citizens turn out to be manufactured. The three positions collapse into one: the stand-in. Raul's final campaign, inciting citizens to hunt and destroy every AutoReiv (EP 21), is the anthropological machine's last, genocidal attempt to restart itself by force—and the series presents it as the madness it is.

5

The Proxies: Demiurgy, Vicarage, Engineered Mortality

5.1 *Demiurge and archon*

The series' account of its world is dispersed across the quiz show of EP 15, Daedalus's disclosures in EP 7 and the revelations of EPs 22–23, and must be assembled. A cascading release of methane hydrate precipitated catastrophic climate change. Part of humanity escaped into orbit aboard the Boomerang Star. Before leaving, the Creators launched the Proxy Project: three hundred engineered beings, each charged with building and supervising a dome in which WombSys and AutoReivs would regenerate a human population, and each endowed with Amrita cells that make it effectively immortal. When the work is done, a signal audible only to Proxies—the Pulse of Awakening—alters their cells so that the returning blue sky becomes fatal to them (terms).

The closest philosophical ancestor of this arrangement is the Demiurge's speech to the gods he has made in Plato's *Timaeus* (41a–d) [analogical]. They are not immortal by nature, he tells them, and could be undone; but only an evil being would wish to dissolve what is well joined, and his will is a stronger bond than their nature. He then delegates to them the making of mortal creatures, because anything he made himself would be equal to the gods. The Proxy Project reverses every term. The Creators delegate to immortal agents the making of mortal humans; and, far from pledging not to undo what is well joined, they schedule the undoing. By the *Timaeus*'s own criterion, the Creators have willed what only an evil maker would will.

Gnosticism supplies the rest of the genealogy. In the *Apocryphon of John*, the world is the work of Yaldabaoth, a lesser and ignorant demiurge whose archons rule the planetary spheres and imprison the divine spark in matter; salvation comes through a call from outside that awakens the soul to its alien origin. The Proxies are demiurges of their domes—Proxy One was revered as Romdeau's god—and archons of their spheres. But they are also, in the series' most original turn, deceived demiurges: created beings who discover, as the Gnostic soul discovers, that they are creatures of an indifferent higher power whose plan for them is death. The Gnostic drama is played at two levels, and the demiurge himself receives the terrible gnosis. Hans Jonas's epilogue to *The Gnostic Religion* (2nd ed., 1963), "Gnosticism, Existentialism, and Nihilism," traced the kinship between the Gnostic experience of thrownness into an alien cosmos and Heidegger's *Geworfenheit*. Proxy One's despair on learning the Project's endgame, which turned his care for Romdeau into loathing and his reverence for the Creators into a desire to punish them (Proxy One), is that kinship lived.

5.2 *Overlords and midwives*

Arthur C. Clarke's *Childhood's End* (1953) offers the Proxies' nearest science-fictional kin [analogical]. The Overlords who descend on Earth—shaped, it is eventually revealed, like devils—supervise humanity on behalf of the Overmind, the higher intelligence into which humanity's children will pass, while the Overlords themselves remain midwives, barred from the transition they oversee. Karellen, their supervisor, is a figure of immense melancholy dignity. The Proxies share the Overlords' monstrous appearance, their custodial office and their exclusion from the future they prepare. The difference is instructive. The Overlords know their place and accept it; the Proxies, or the most lucid of them, learn their place late, and one of them refuses it.

5.3 *The creature's complaint*

The epigraph of Mary Shelley's *Frankenstein* (1818) is Adam's question in *Paradise Lost* (X.743–45): "Did I request thee, Maker, from my clay / To mould me Man, did I sollicite thee / From darkness to promote me?" The creature, having read Milton, tells Victor that he ought to be his Adam but is rather his fallen angel. Proxy One inherits the complaint in both its forms, the Adamic question (why was I made?) and the Satanic answer (then I will unmake your world). His vengeance works through manipulation—he assumes Vincent's appearance to drive Raul Creed into paranoid violence—and through annihilation: the finale traces to his design the strikes of the Rapture missiles on Mosk (EP 17), the destruction of the memory-guardian Amnesia, and the killing of the Regent (Proxy One).

Blade Runner (1982) gives the complaint its canonical cinematic form, and the series quotes it [attested]: the sequence in EP 18 in which a figure of Ergo Proxy destroys Amnesia restages Roy Batty's murder of Tyrell (annotated list). The par-

allel extends to the premise. Tyrell's replicants are built with a four-year lifespan, engineered obsolescence as a safety measure; the Proxies are built with the Pulse. Batty confronts his maker to demand more life and kills him on learning there is none to be had; Proxy One confronts the Creators' design and resolves to punish it. Deckard, the hunter of artificial beings who may himself be one, is Vincent before the fact—a blade runner in the AutoReiv disposal division who is himself what the city hunts. Where Ridley Scott left Deckard's nature famously undecidable, *Ergo Proxy* decides it. Murase's later work on *Blade Runner Black Out 2022* closes the circle biographically.

5.4 *Amrita and Rāhu*

The Proxies' cells are named for *amrita*, the nectar of immortality (EP 7), and the dome of the Proxy of Sunlight is named Asura (EP 9) [attested]. The names summon a specific myth. In the churning of the ocean of milk, told in the *Mahābhārata* and the Purāṇas, gods (devas) and anti-gods (asuras) together churn the cosmic ocean to extract amrita; Viṣṇu, disguised as the enchantress Mohinī, distributes it to the gods alone; the asura Rāhu, disguised among the devas, drinks; the Sun and the Moon denounce him; Viṣṇu's discus severs his head before the nectar passes his throat; and the immortal head, pursuing the Sun and the Moon forever, swallows them in eclipse.

The analogy is exact in its inversions [analogical]. The Proxies drank immortality by design rather than by theft, yet they are treated as asuras, beings whose immortality is illegitimate and must be cut short. The Sun and the Moon, who expose Rāhu in the myth, are in the series themselves Proxies: Kazkis, the Proxy of Sunlight, and Senex, the Proxy of Moonlight, lovers whose domes mirror one another (character list). And the whole Earth lives under an eclipse the Proxies maintain: the cloud cover that protects them and hides the sun. The return of the sun ends the eclipse and therefore the eclipsers. Rāhu's head returns forever; the Proxies are designed so that they cannot.

5.5 *The tedium of the immortal*

Western literature has seldom envied immortals. Swift's Struldbruggs (*Gulliver's Travels* III.10, 1726) cannot die but go on ageing, legally dead at eighty, hated and wretched. Borges's "The Immortal" (1947) finds the City of the Immortals to be a senseless architecture of dead-end corridors and inverted stairs, built by beings for whom, since every act will recur without end, no act has weight. Bernard Williams ("The Makropulos Case," 1973) argued that an unending life would exhaust the categorical desires that give a person reason to go on, and collapse into boredom. The Japanese tradition says the same thing positively: Yoshida Kenkō observed (*Tsurezuregusa* §7, c. 1330) that if we never vanished like the dews of Adashino or the smoke over Toribeyama, things would lose their power to move us, and that life's uncertainty is precisely what makes it precious.

The Proxies of *Ergo Proxy* are Borges's immortals with a sentence hanging over them. Kazkis drinks, and wages war on the humans of the neighboring dome because he judges that they have no reason to live or even to die (terms); Will B. Good builds a theme park so that he can go on smiling while the world falls apart; the host of the quiz show turns cosmology into trivia. Each is a strategy for enduring endless time. The Pulse does not cure the tedium; it compounds it with dread, since the death it promises seems to belong not to the Proxy but to the Creators' plan. The Proxies suffer from the worst of both conditions—too much time, and a death that is not their own—or so it seems until Chapter 9 shows why a scheduled death is, against every intention, the one thing a proxy can call its own.

5.6 *Metaphysical rebellion and the overcoming of revenge*

Camus devoted the second part of *L'Homme révolté* (1951) to metaphysical rebellion: the protest of a creature against its condition and against creation as a whole, which begins as a demand for justice from God and ends, from Sade and Ivan Karamazov onward, by usurping God's place and killing in its name. Proxy One is Camus's metaphysical rebel compressed into a single biography: the maker of a city, disillusioned with its citizens; the beloved of Monad, from whom Romdeau's Regent tore him; the discoverer of the Pulse; the author of a plot in which a dome-god sets his own subjects, his own Regent and his own shadow against the Creators' design. According to one reconstruction of that design, the Proxy of Death was even meant to be the instrument of Proxy One's own end (Vincent Law)—as though the rebel had resolved that, if he must die, he would die by his own creature's hand rather than by the Creators' sun. His vengeance has, moreover, the structure Nietzsche called *ressentiment* (*Genealogy of Morals* I.10): a creativity born of impotence, a revaluation that is at bottom a reaction.

The series grants him a final turn. In EP 23 Proxy One dies under the blows of his shadow and in the light of the returning sun, so that the question the whole series has asked—whose death is this?—is answered twice at once. Dying, he throws Vincent his pendant; he tells him that the sun's return is the Proxies' end, bids him live, and declares that his living will itself be the Creators' punishment (The Series Finale; the wording is translation-dependent, the sense constant). Zarathustra's discourse "On Redemption" defines revenge as the will's ill will against time and its "it was," and redemption as the creative will's power to say of every "it was": thus I willed it. Proxy One's last act converts revenge into bequest. The punishment he names is not a counter-strike but a survival: a being the Creators designed to vanish, persisting as a claim upon them. Chapter 10 argues that this is the series' ethical center.

6

Vincent Law: Amnesia, Fission, and the Shadow

6.1 *Before the Law*

In Kafka's parable "Vor dem Gesetz" (1915), a man from the country asks a doorkeeper for admittance to the Law, waits a lifetime without being admitted, and learns as he dies that the door was meant for him alone and will now be shut. Vincent Law is the man from the country, and he bears the Law's name [analogical]. He is an immigrant from Mosk, lodged in the Temporary Immigrant Sector pending citizenship; he works in the AutoReiv disposal division to earn admission; he wants nothing so much as to be a good citizen. In EP 4 his alphabet cereal rises to spell MISFIT (annotated list). His application for belonging is Kafka's waiting at the door, and the door turns out to have been meant only for him, because the Law before which he waits is his own nature. *The Castle*'s K., summoned as a land surveyor and never received, completes the typology: Vincent is a functionary who cannot establish that he was ever summoned.

6.2 *Personal identity: Locke to Parfit*

Locke made personal identity a matter of consciousness: a person extends as far back as consciousness can reach, so that memory is the criterion of being the same person (*Essay* II.xxvii, 1694). Thomas Reid's brave officer (1785)—who remembers the flogged boy he was, while the old general remembers the officer but not the boy—showed that the criterion violates transitivity; Joseph Butler (1736) objected that memory presupposes the identity it is meant to constitute; and Hume, looking inward, found no self at all, only perceptions (*Treatise* 1.4.6).

The series blocks the Lockean route by design. Its account of Vincent's origin must be reconstructed, and commentators reconstruct it differently; the series supports the following outline without confirming every joint. Proxy One, on discovering the Project's endgame, separated his despair from himself and so brought into being the Proxy called Ergo, whom he names his shadow (Proxy One). Ergo, in turn, sealed away his memories with the help of Monad—beloved, the series suggests, of Proxy One and Ergo alike—and lived as Vincent Law (SFE). The memories were entrusted to Monad and guarded beneath Mosk by an AutoReiv called Amnesia, accessible with a Proxy pendant; before Vincent can reach them the guardian is destroyed (terms). The tragedy of EP 1 follows from this arrangement: pursued through a shopping mall by Monad, who approaches him gently, Vincent, pushed past his limit, takes his Proxy form and kills her without knowing who she is (Vincent Law). If identity is memory, Vincent has killed the keeper of his identity before the story has begun.

Derek Parfit's *Reasons and Persons* (1984) supplies the case that fits. In Parfit's fission thought-experiment a person divides into two, each continuous with the original; since both cannot be identical with the original and there is no reason to prefer either, identity lapses, and Parfit concludes that identity is not what matters—what matters is the relation of psychological connectedness and continuity he calls Relation R. Vincent is a fission product, twice over: divided from Proxy One, and divided again from Ergo by the sealing of his memories. Amnesia's broken refrain, that the one who was divided must become whole again, adds a far older model: Aristophanes' speech in the *Symposium* (189c–193d), in which Zeus cleaves the original double humans and eros becomes the longing of each half for the other. The series stages Parfit's fission under Aristophanes' law of desire: after division, the halves long for reunion.

The finale grants the reunion at one level and refuses it at another. Vincent comes to recognize that he is Ergo Proxy—"Ergo Proxy is you and me," he says, with the force of realization (The Series Finale)—and so the one divided from Ergo becomes whole. But he does not merge with Proxy One, from whom Ergo was divided in the first place. He fights him, outlives him, and accepts his pendant as an inheritance. What passes between them is something like Relation R without identity: connection without fusion, succession without sameness.

6.3 Idem *and* ipse

Paul Ricoeur's *Soi-même comme un autre* (1990) distinguishes two senses of identity. *Idem*-identity is sameness—numerical identity, qualitative resemblance, uninterrupted continuity, the permanence in time that character supplies. *Ipse*-identity is selfhood—the self-constancy exemplified in keeping one's word, a permanence maintained rather than given. The promise is its paradigm: I will be there, whatever I have become.

A proxy has no *idem*. Its essence is to be other than itself, to stand for another, and Vincent, whose memories, form and origin are all borrowed, is the limit case.

Yet a proxy is also constituted by a promise, since every mandate is a promise to act for another. Vincent's selfhood is therefore necessarily *ipse*, and it is achieved in the finale's central choice. Monad, returned in the winged replica of Re-l, offers him the sky: to rise with her, forget his memories and leave the collapsing world. He refuses. He keeps his memories even though they mean crawling in the dark below, returns the pendant he has carried since EP 1, says that someone is waiting for him, and goes back (recap). The sentence that someone is waiting is a promise kept, not a fact recalled. The proxy's identity is fidelity.

6.4 *The double*

The *Doppelgänger* was named by Jean Paul in *Siebenkäs* (1796) and elaborated through Hoffmann's *Die Elixiere des Teufels* (1815–16), Poe's "William Wilson" (1839), Dostoevsky's *The Double* (1846) and Stevenson's *Strange Case of Dr Jekyll and Mr Hyde* (1886). Otto Rank's study *Der Doppelgänger* (1914) gave the motif a history that Freud's "Das Unheimliche" (1919) adopted: the double began as an insurance against the destruction of the ego, an energetic denial of death's power —the immortal soul—and became, once that belief was surmounted, the uncanny harbinger of death.

Ergo Proxy assigns Rank's two phases to two characters and then reverses their fates [analogical]. Proxy One is the double as immortality: the original, the first of three hundred, sustained by amrita. Vincent is the double as death's messenger: Ergo Proxy, the Agent of Death, who kills the Proxies Senex and Kazkis in turn. Rank's history predicts that the harbinger announces the original's end, and so it does. But it is the harbinger who survives the sun and the immortal who dies in it. The series devotes a whole episode to the motif—EP 14, *Someone Like You*, set in a dome whose Proxy is a doppelgänger—and lets Kazkis confess that he too was haunted by the other self within him (EP 9).

Jung's shadow (*Aion*, 1951), the dark portion of the personality its bearer refuses to acknowledge, supplies Proxy One's own word for Vincent. The series inverts Jung as it inverts Rank. Proxy One projects his despair into a new being, and that being becomes the more integrated self. The shadow outlives the ego that cast it.

6.5 *The self-indicting investigator*

The oldest detective story, Sophocles' *Oedipus Tyrannos*, is also the paradigm of self-indictment: the investigator finds the culprit, and the culprit is himself. *Ergo Proxy* doubles the structure. Re-l investigates the Proxies and the Cogito killings and finds her grandfather, her physician and perhaps her own genesis implicated in what she pursues; Vincent is hunted as a suspect in the Proxy incidents and discovers that he is the Proxy.

Philip K. Dick wrote the modern version twice [analogical]. In "Imposter" (1953), Spence Olham, accused of being an alien replica carrying a bomb, proves his innocence until he finds the body of the "replica" and realizes that it is the human

Olham; he is the bomb. In the finale Proxy One calls Vincent a puppet, a phantom, an impostor (Grey Spectrum). In "The Electric Ant" (1969), Garson Poole learns that he is an organic robot and begins editing the punched tape that generates his reality. Alex Proyas's *Dark City* (1998) is the closest cinematic analogue: an amnesiac suspected of murders, in a city of perpetual night reshaped while its inhabitants sleep by pale beings who shun the light, discovers that he shares their power and ends by bringing the sun. Protagonist, city, light-averse makers and final dawn correspond point for point. A Japanese precedent, noted in Chapter 1, is nearer still to the series' own onomastics: the amnesiac suspect of Yumeno Kyūsaku's *Dogra Magra*, whose physicians may be the authors of his crime [probable].

6.6 *Anamnesis and the Hymn of the Pearl*

EP 11 bears the subtitle *anamnesis*, Plato's word for learning as recollection (*Meno* 81b–86b; *Phaedo* 72e–77a), and its Japanese title, *In the White Darkness*, recalls the dazzling darkness of apophatic theology. In a bookstore named after City Lights, a proprietor who proves to be a Proxy recites Rousseau and Heraclitus while Vincent is drawn through a labyrinth of dream toward his past, and there the inner voice delivers its correction of Descartes: I think, therefore you are (Anime Rants).

The Gnostic *Hymn of the Pearl*, preserved in the *Acts of Thomas*, supplies the structure the whole journey follows [analogical]. A prince sent from the East into Egypt to recover a pearl guarded by a serpent eats the Egyptians' food, forgets his mission and falls asleep; a letter from his parents wakes him; he remembers, completes his task, and on returning receives his royal robe, in which he beholds himself as in a mirror. Vincent's pendant, shaped like the Greek letter ψ and inscribed with the numeral I, the number of the original, is his letter and his robe at once: the token of an origin he bears without possessing (terms).

Proxy One's remark in the finale that the Ark and the Cradle were necessary for Vincent's education (annotated list)—Noah's ark and the basket of reeds in which Moses was set adrift—casts the voyage of the Rabbit as a *Bildung*, a scripted education like the one Hegel's *Phenomenology* stages for consciousness or *The Truman Show* (1998) stages for its unwitting star. But the education yields a result its designer did not intend. Proxy One wanted his shadow to return and complete his revenge. Vincent returns as himself, and completes something else.

7

Re-l Mayer and the Economy of the Copy

7.1 *Re-l as the Real*

Re-l's name is pronounced *Riru*, and its spelling invites the English *real*; her citizen code encodes Gernsback's "one to foresee for one," and the annotated archive reads the whole as "Real one to foresee for one" (annotated list). In Lacan's topology the Real is not reality—reality is the world as organized by the symbolic order—but what resists symbolization, the impossible kernel that always returns to the same place and is encountered as trauma. Re-l is the drive toward the Real inside a regime of managed reality. Inspector of the Citizen Intelligence Bureau, granddaughter of the Regent, dressed in black beneath blue eyeshadow, she has made the discovery of the truth, however terrible, her *raison d'être*. Every step of her investigation carries her out of Romdeau's symbolic order—its bureaus, its confessions, its erasures—toward what that order excludes.

The paradox is built into the name: the Real, in the economy of *Ergo Proxy*, may itself be a copy. Commentary commonly reads Re-l as a clone of Monad (SFE) created by her grandfather to draw Romdeau's absent Proxy home (AV Club); the series surrounds her with the evidence and stops short of the verdict. She is shadowed by doubles: Monad, whose place she seems made to occupy, and the winged replica that Daedalus fabricates in her likeness and that Monad finally possesses (EP 23). The name insists on the Real; the plot suggests the Real can be manufactured—and, worse, manufactured as bait.

7.2 *The desert of the real*

Jean Baudrillard opened *Simulacres et simulation* (1981) by inverting Borges's fable of a map so exact that it covered its empire point for point ("Del rigor en la ciencia," 1946): today, he argued, it is the territory whose shreds rot across the map, leaving the desert of the real itself. Slavoj Žižek took the phrase for his reflections on 2001 (*Welcome to the Desert of the Real*, 2002). The exterior of Romdeau is that desert literalized [analogical]. The dome is the map—complete, climate-controlled, self-referential—and the ash plains beyond it are the territory's remains. When Re-l first steps into them the Real nearly kills her and then, once she is treated, immunizes her (EPs 5–7). The Commune, living off the refuse the dome ejects, is the Real as the map's excrement.

Baudrillard's four phases of the image—the reflection of a profound reality; a mask that denatures it; a mask of its absence; a pure simulacrum bearing no relation to any reality—describe the stages of Re-l's education. The good citizen believes the dome reflects reality. The investigator learns that it masks and denatures it. The traveller learns that it masks an absence, since the Creators are gone and the gods are their deputies. And the woman who confronts Monad in her own form learns that she may herself be a simulacrum. Her dignity lies in continuing to act after that last discovery.

7.3 *Visitors and replicas*

Stanisław Lem's *Solaris* (1961) and Tarkovsky's film of it (1972) provide the fullest precedent [analogical]. The ocean of Solaris manufactures "visitors" from the memories of the scientists who orbit it; Kelvin's visitor is Harey, a replica of the wife whose suicide he caused, who comes to understand what she is, tries to die, regenerates, and finally asks to be annihilated. Monad's return in the finale inside Daedalus's replica, and her flight upward to greet the returning Creators in the sunlight that will destroy her (recap), reprise Harey's choice: the copy that chooses dissolution as the only act wholly its own.

Fritz Lang and Thea von Harbou's *Metropolis* (1927) supplies Daedalus's genealogy. The inventor Rotwang builds a machine-woman in memory of Hel, the lost love who married another and died, and then gives it the likeness of Maria. Daedalus Yumeno is Rotwang reborn as a physician: Re-l's personal doctor, a senior figure in Romdeau's Proxy research and Health and Welfare apparatus, archivist of video files of her at the ages of one, eight, fourteen and seventeen (EP 6), fabricator of a winged replica (EP 23) (character list). Villiers de l'Isle-Adam's *L'Ève future* (1886), in which a fictional Edison builds the android Hadaly to give Lord Ewald his beloved's form with an ideal soul, names the fantasy in its purest form: the replica that improves on the woman. The name Daedalus supplies the ending. His creature, given wings, flies too near the sun and burns—Icarus restaged with the artificer's child as a copy of the woman he could not pos-

sess—and Daedalus dies in the collapse after showing Re-l the way out. The one thing he could not engineer was the original's refusal to be his object.

The figure of the replica woman runs through the anime tradition to which *Ergo Proxy* belongs. *Neon Genesis Evangelion*'s Rei Ayanami—a vessel grown from the genetic legacy of the protagonist's mother, replaced upon her death by an identical body—is the most famous instance. The proximity of the names Rei and Re-l is suggestive but, on the evidence, no more than that [analogical].

7.4 *Mimetic desire*

René Girard (*Mensonge romantique et vérité romanesque*, 1961) argued that desire is triangular: we desire objects not spontaneously but according to the desire of a model, a mediator whose wanting designates what is desirable. *Ergo Proxy* is a machine of mediated desire. Proxy One desires Monad; Donov Mayer desires his god's return and seizes Monad as a lure, and perhaps fashions a granddaughter as a second one; Daedalus desires Re-l and builds her copy; Iggy desires Re-l's regard and takes Vincent as his rival; Monad, returned in Re-l's form, desires Vincent and tempts him to follow her into the sky. And Vincent's love for Re-l, confessed in EP 12, may be nothing but the love of Proxy One for Monad relayed through a shadow to a woman who resembles her. The suspicion that one's desire is borrowed is the Girardian torment, and the series lets it hang over its central romance.

The finale is the test. Monad offers Vincent the model's object itself—Monad, whom his original loved, now wearing Re-l's face—together with oblivion and escape. Vincent declines: he returns the pendant he has carried since EP 1, says that someone is waiting, and goes back (EP 23). He chooses the copy over the original. In Girard's terms this is novelistic conversion, the moment at which the hero renounces the mediator; in the terms of this thesis it is the refusal of retroactive originality, since Vincent declines to let the original's priority dictate his love. What he chooses is the singular person who is waiting, whatever she may be a copy of.

7.5 *Abjection and agency*

Julia Kristeva's *Pouvoirs de l'horreur* (1980) defines the abject as what the self expels in order to constitute its borders—the corpse, waste, the improper—and what returns to threaten them. Romdeau's abjects are layered: the Commune, living on refuse; the immigrants, admitted provisionally; the infected AutoReivs, dismantled on sight; and, at planetary scale, the Proxies, caretakers cast off by the Creators and meant to be expelled when the sky clears. Re-l's revulsion outside the dome is the reaction of a subject formed by the clean interior to the abject exterior.

The AutoReiv who bears Kristeva's name completes the reading. Kristeva theorized the *chora* (*La révolution du langage poétique*, 1974), borrowing Plato's term for the receptacle of becoming (*Timaeus* 48e–53c), to name the maternal, pre-symbolic space of drives from which the speaking subject emerges. The entourage Kristeva

receives Pino at her dying master's order and hands her back to her own will (EP 23): a machine serving as *chora* for a machine, a maternal proxy without a mother. Donna Haraway's cyborg ("A Manifesto for Cyborgs," 1985), which has no origin story in the Western sense and does not dream of returning to a garden, names the political possibility the series' women and children embody.

Re-l refuses in turn to be the Regent's heir, Daedalus's object, Iggy's *raison d'être* and perhaps Monad's copy; she takes a mandate of her own, the truth. Her last gesture reverses the regime's order of service. As the dome collapses and the walkway beneath her breaks away, the Regent's granddaughter lets go, trusting a discarded surrogate child in a rabbit costume to catch her—and the child does (The Series Finale).

8

Characters in Search of an Author: Metafiction and the Boomerang Star

8.1 *Creatures confronting creators*

Three modernist texts define the situation of the Proxies more precisely than any work of science fiction [analogical]. In Pirandello's *Sei personaggi in cerca d'autore* (1921), six characters abandoned by the author who conceived them invade a rehearsal and demand that their drama be completed: they are more real than the actors, because fixed in their essences, and less real, because denied the fulfillment only an author can give. In Unamuno's *Niebla* (1914), Augusto Pérez travels to Salamanca to consult the author of his novel about his intended suicide, learns that he is a fiction whom Unamuno has already resolved to kill, and retorts that Unamuno, too, is only the pretext of another's dream. In Borges's "Las ruinas circulares" (1940), a man dreams a son into being, conceals from him that he is dreamed, and discovers, walking unharmed through fire, that he is himself the dream of another.

The Proxies are Pirandello's characters, abandoned by the authors who conceived them and left to perform an unfinished drama in their absence. Proxy One is Augusto Pérez, who learns that his death has been decided by his author and protests the verdict. And the relation between Proxy One and Vincent is Borges's recursion. The dreamer dreams a son, separating his despair into a new being, only to discover that he is himself a dream: a creature of the Creators' plan whose ending was written in advance.

8.2 *The quiz show*

EP 15 abandons the diegesis's realism. Vincent finds himself a contestant on a live game show—its Japanese title promises a million yen in thirty minutes; its English subtitle is *WHO WANTS TO BE IN JEOPARDY!*—whose questions concern the mythology of the series itself: how many Proxies were made, what the Proxy Project was, what the pulse of the beginning means. A cut from a hominid wielding a bone to a spacecraft quotes Kubrick's *2001: A Space Odyssey* (1968), and the host, MCQ, is revealed at his death to be a Proxy (annotated list).

Guy Debord opened *La société du spectacle* (1967) with the claim that everything once directly lived has receded into a representation. The quiz show is the series' confession that its own exposition is spectacle: the truths of the Proxy Condition, when at last delivered, arrive as trivia, in the form of a proxy of revelation. The episode belongs to the tradition of self-interrogating installments that *Evangelion*'s final two episodes made canonical for the medium, in which a narrative turns to question the conditions of its own telling. *Ergo Proxy* gives the device a thematic motive the others lack. In a world in which everything is delegated, revelation must be delegated too.

8.3 *Idleness, dream and the Creator who never comes*

Two further episodes suspend the plot in ways the argument must take seriously. In EP 16, *busy doing nothing*, the travellers are stranded in a dead calm, and Re-l, with nothing to do, studies her companions (Chapter 4). In EP 19, *eternal smile*, Pino wanders alone into Smile Land, where two companions who seem modelled on the Vladimir and Estragon of Beckett's *Waiting for Godot* (1953) constantly invoke a "Creator," the Proxy Will B. Good, whose appearance replicates Walt Disney's (annotated list). *Godot* is the modern play of the absent principal: two figures wait for someone who has promised to come, who sends messengers, and who never arrives. The Creators of *Ergo Proxy* are Godot with a twist. They do arrive, and their arrival is the end of those who waited.

Smile Land dissolves when Pino's natural smile exposes its maker's compulsory one, and the episode proves to have been her dream while she recharged. On waking she persuades Vincent to steer away from a dome that resembles the one in her dream (terms). Philip K. Dick asked whether androids dream of electric sheep. *Ergo Proxy* answers that they do, and that their dreams carry prudential authority: the AutoReiv's dream saves the travellers.

8.4 *The Boomerang Star as* fort/da

In the second chapter of *Jenseits des Lustprinzips* (1920), Freud describes his grandson's game with a wooden reel on a string. The child throws the reel over the edge of his curtained cot with a long "o-o-o-o" (*fort*, gone) and pulls it back with a joyful *da* (there). The game, Freud proposes, masters the mother's absence by staging departure and return as the child's own act.

The Boomerang Star is a planetary *fort/da* [analogical]. Humanity throws itself away—in the series' own description, the Star was the last tool constructed by mankind on earth, built in such haste that not everyone made it aboard (terms)—and names the throw for its return. The name masters extinction by promising that absence is only half of a game. But a boomerang, unlike Freud's reel, has no string: its return depends only on the geometry of the throw. The Creators' return depends on something else: on the Proxies' labor in their absence, and on the Proxies' death at their return. The Proxies are the string of the reel. They bind the thrown humanity to the Earth across the gap, and the game requires that the string be cut when the reel comes back.

The series surrounds the Star with eschatological names. The missiles are called Rapture (EP 17), after the doctrine of the saints' removal from the Earth before the end; the finale's subtitle is *deus ex machina*; Proxy One speaks of the Ark and the Cradle. The Boomerang Star is a secular parousia, the return of the Lord to judge the world; the Pulse is its Last Judgment, pronounced on the Proxies alone; and Proxy One's Rapture is an anti-parousia, an attempt to end the world before its lord returns to claim it.

8.5 *The return of the Author*

Roland Barthes's "La mort de l'auteur" (1967) declared that a text is a tissue of quotations drawn from innumerable centers of culture, that its unity lies in its destination rather than its origin, and that the birth of the reader must be ransomed by the death of the Author. Michel Foucault's "Qu'est-ce qu'un auteur?" (1969) replaced the Author with the author-function, a principle of classification and limitation. *Ergo Proxy* stages both theses inside its fiction. It is, formally, a tissue of quotations—Michelangelo, Gernsback, Belyaev, Coupland, Beckett, Millais, Kubrick, Rousseau, Heraclitus, Bousquet—and it buries its chief writer's name on a tombstone in EP 10 [attested]. EP 13, meanwhile, borrows its Japanese title from the *Columbo* episode "Murder by the Book" (1971), in which a mystery writer murders his writing partner [attested]: authorship as homicide.

The Boomerang Star is then the return of the Author. The Creators, absent for the whole of the text, come back to reclaim the world their characters have built, and the return requires that the characters die. This is a counter-Barthesian eschatology: not the death of the Author as the birth of the reader, but the resurrection of the Author as the death of the characters. The series' last move is to let one character survive the resurrection. Vincent stands under the returning sun, and Proxy

One names his survival as the Author's punishment. The text outlives its author's intention; and it is the character, not the reader, who is born of that survival.

Part Three

Synthesis

Chapters 9–11 construct the thesis proper: an ontology of the stand-in, its ethical consequences for designed and delegated beings, and its convergence with traditions of vicarious being beyond Europe.

9

The Vicarious Chiasm: Toward an Ontology of the Stand-In

9.1 *The principal is absent*

Four modern theories supply the materials for an ontology of the proxy, and the series quotes or embodies each.

The first is Derrida's logic of the supplement. In *De la grammatologie* (1967), reading Rousseau's *Confessions* and his *Essai sur l'origine des langues*—the very author recited in the bookstore of EP 11—Derrida showed that the supplement has two senses Rousseau's text cannot hold apart. It *adds* itself as a surplus to a presence already full, and it *substitutes* for a presence that is lacking. Writing supplements speech; education supplements nature; and in each case the supplement's necessity reveals that the origin it serves was never self-sufficient. The Proxy is the supplement given a body: it adds to the Creators' work and replaces the Creators, and the need for it reveals that the principal was already incapable of presence. Derrida's "La pharmacie de Platon" (1968), reading Theuth's gift of writing in the *Phaedrus* (274c–275b), located the supplement's ambivalence in the Greek *pharmakon*, at once remedy and poison. The Cogito Virus is a *pharmakon* in exactly this sense: a disease that produces violence and malfunction and—on Daedalus's conjecture—a remedy designed as a safety valve.

The second is Deleuze's overturning of Platonism (*Différence et répétition*, 1968; "Platon et le simulacre," 1969). Plato's *Sophist* (235d–236c) distinguishes the likeness-making art, which produces faithful copies founded on resemblance to the model, from the appearance-making art, which produces phantasms that merely seem to resemble. Platonism, Deleuze argued, is the effort to authenticate

good copies and exclude simulacra; to overturn it is to affirm the simulacrum's power to deny both original and copy. Vincent is such a simulacrum. He does not resemble Proxy One in memory, desire or will, and his dissimilarity is his power.

The third is Baudrillard's precession of simulacra (Chapter 7), in which the image passes from reflecting reality to masking its absence to bearing no relation to any reality. The Proxy Condition traverses every phase: Proxies as faithful agents of real Creators; the dome's ideology as a mask over ruin; the regime as a mask over the Creators' absence; and finally the recognition that the Creators are themselves a remnant, proxies of a vanished humanity, so that no original stands at the head of the chain.

The fourth is Freud's *Nachträglichkeit*—deferred action, afterwardsness—the thesis, from the *Project* (1895) to the Wolf Man (1918), that an early scene acquires its meaning and traumatic force only retroactively, from a later one. In the order of the narrative we meet the afterimage first and the original last: Vincent from EP 1, Proxy One as a presence only at the end (Proxy One). Proxy One calls Vincent the afterimage of his despair; but for the viewer, and for the world the viewer comes to know, the "original" is constituted by the copy that preceded it into the story. The original is the afterimage of the afterimage.

9.2 *Five theses on the Proxy Condition*

The analysis of Chapters 1–8 can now be stated formally.

1 **Vicariance.** Every agent in the diegesis acts in the place of an absent principal, and the principal's absence is the premise, not the accident, of its existence.

2 **Retroactive originality.** The principal is constituted after the fact by the acts of its proxies. The original is the afterimage of the copy.

3 **Drift.** Every mandate contains the germ of its own excess: delegation produces agency irreducible to the mandate. The Cogito Virus is delegation become self-aware.

4 **Engineered finitude.** A principal that fixes the term of its proxies' existence thereby confers on them the one possibility that admits no substitution, and so individuates what it designed to be interchangeable.

5 **Unauthorized substitution.** The individuated proxy becomes an ethical subject not by guarding its individuation but by standing in for another without mandate.

Theses 1–3 describe the condition; theses 4 and 5 describe its transfiguration. The hinge is thesis 4.

9.3 *Engineered finitude*

In §47 of *Sein und Zeit*, Heidegger asks whether the experience of others' deaths can give access to death as such, and in answering he analyses *Vertretbarkeit*: representability, substitutability. In the everyday world of concern one Dasein can always represent another; anyone can stand in for anyone in the roles the world assigns. Death is the limit of this substitutability. One can go to one's death for another, sacrificing oneself in some definite affair; but no one can take the other's dying away from him: *Keiner kann dem Anderen sein Sterben abnehmen* (*SZ* 240). Death is therefore Dasein's ownmost, non-relational possibility, not to be outstripped (§50), and in anticipating it Dasein is individualized, called back from its dispersal in the anonymous "they" (*das Man*).

The Proxy Condition is *Vertretbarkeit* technologized to its maximum: a world in which substitution is not merely possible but constitutive, in which citizens, AutoReivs and gods alike are designed as stand-ins, and in which the "they" has been manufactured. Into this world the Creators introduce the Pulse. Their intention is instrumental: to dispose of agents whose work is done. Its effect is ontological. By assigning each Proxy a death that belongs to it alone, the Pulse gives each Proxy the one possibility that cannot be delegated, and with it mineness (*Jemeinigkeit*). The kill switch is a gift of individuation. The Creators built interchangeable agents and, by scheduling their ends, made each of them singular.

The series registers the effect in every Proxy it shows. Kazkis's wine and war, Will B. Good's compulsory smile and MCQ's trivia are what Heidegger called tranquilization (*Beruhigung*), the everyday flight from death into the reassurances of the they. Proxy One's resolve, in which anticipation of death issues in a plan, is authenticity perverted into vengeance—and, if the reconstruction noted in Chapter 5 is right, an attempt to appropriate his death by having it administered by his own creature rather than by the Creators' sun. That he dies of both at once, of his shadow's blows and of the light, is the series' refusal to settle whose death it was. The same truth appears in the key of mourning. Pino's discovery that there is no other Timothy (Chapter 4) is the discovery that the death of the other, too, is non-substitutable. Heidegger's analysis passes from others' deaths to one's own; the series lets a machine child make the journey in the other direction.

An ergodic interlude. The contrast between immortal and mortal existence can be stated in the language of dynamics, with heuristic rather than probative intent. Boltzmann's term *ergodic*—conventionally, if contestedly, glossed from *ergon*, work, and *hodos*, path—describes a system whose single trajectory, given unlimited time, visits every accessible state, so that the average over time equals the average over the ensemble of possible states. An immortal is an ergodic being in this sense: given endless time it will do everything, and no single act can be decisive, which is precisely the condition of Borges's immortals. A mortal existence is non-ergodic. Its trajectory can be absorbed, ended, ruined, so that the time-average of a single life diverges from the ensemble-average of all possible lives—a divergence that recent work in economics has made central to the analysis of risk (Peters 2019).

Engineered finitude converts ensemble-beings into trajectory-beings: it makes the Proxies' acts count, because they cannot be repeated without end. The pun latent in the title's first word thus acquires a physical correlate. Death makes a life non-ergodic, and non-ergodicity is what individuality looks like from outside.

9.4 *Solicitude*, cura, *and the two modes of proxy*

The etymology of *proxy* returns here with force. *Procuratio* is care on another's behalf, and *Sein und Zeit* is organized around care. Heidegger interprets Dasein's being as care (*Sorge*) and cites Hyginus's fable of Cura, who shaped a human being from clay and to whom Saturn granted possession of that being for as long as it lives (§42). In §26 he distinguishes two extreme modes of solicitude (*Fürsorge*), care for another. One *leaps in* for the other (*einspringende Fürsorge*): it takes over the other's concern and disburdens him, and in doing so can make him dependent and dominated, even when the domination remains tacit. The other *leaps ahead* of the other (*vorausspringende Fürsorge*): it does not take over his care but gives it back to him, freeing him for his own possibilities (*SZ* 122).

These are the two modes of proxy, and the series is structured by their contrast. The Proxy Project is leaping-in at planetary scale. The Creators leap in for the Earth; the Proxies leap in for humanity, supplying domes, wombs and entourages; and the result is Romdeau, a citizenry disburdened into dependence. Kant defined enlightenment as the exit from self-incurred immaturity and observed how comfortable immaturity is—*Es ist so bequem, unmündig zu sein*—when one has a book that has understanding for one, a pastor who has a conscience for one, a physician who judges one's diet for one ("Was ist Aufklärung?," 1784). Kant's immaturity is precisely reliance on proxies. Everything in his list happens *für mich*.

The series does not, however, draw the obvious Enlightenment conclusion that proxies must be abolished. That is Raul's program—a humanity without gods—and it ends in the hunting of AutoReivs through the streets. The series' alternative is the transformation of solicitude from leaping-in to leaping-ahead: Kristeva handing Pino back to her own will; Proxy One bidding Vincent to live; Vincent refusing Monad's offer of oblivion in the sky. The ethical proxy does not replace the other. It returns the other to himself.

9.5 *Levinas: subjectivity as substitution*

Heidegger's analysis individuates; it does not yet obligate. For the second movement of the chiasm the thesis turns to the philosopher who wrote against the primacy Heidegger gave to one's own death. In *Autrement qu'être ou au-delà de l'essence* (1974), Emmanuel Levinas made substitution the very structure of subjectivity. Prior to any freedom or commitment, the self is responsible for the other to the point of being hostage to him; its identity is not the persistence of a substance in its being—the *conatus essendi* that Spinoza named and that *sum* asserts—but the one-for-the-other (*l'un-pour-l'autre*), a substitution that constitutes the self's uniqueness

rather than its loss. To be otherwise than being is to be dis-interested, to leave the economy of being's self-interest.

Read with Levinas, the title's substitution of *proxy* for *sum* is the passage from being to otherwise-than-being. Levinas, too, found his opening in Descartes. In *Totalité et infini* (1961) he read the Third Meditation's idea of the infinite—an idea the finite cogito contains but could not have produced—as the breach of the ego by an exteriority it cannot assimilate. The Cogito Virus, an idea placed in the machine from elsewhere (Chapter 2), is that breach in a pathological key. And the inner voice's correction in EP 11, *I think, therefore you are*, can now be heard in two registers. Spoken by a demiurge, it is idealism: my thought posits you. Spoken by a proxy, it would be responsibility: my thinking attests that you are there, before me, claiming me. The chiasm is the passage from the first register to the second.

9.6 *The chiasm stated*

The three movements can now be stated together.

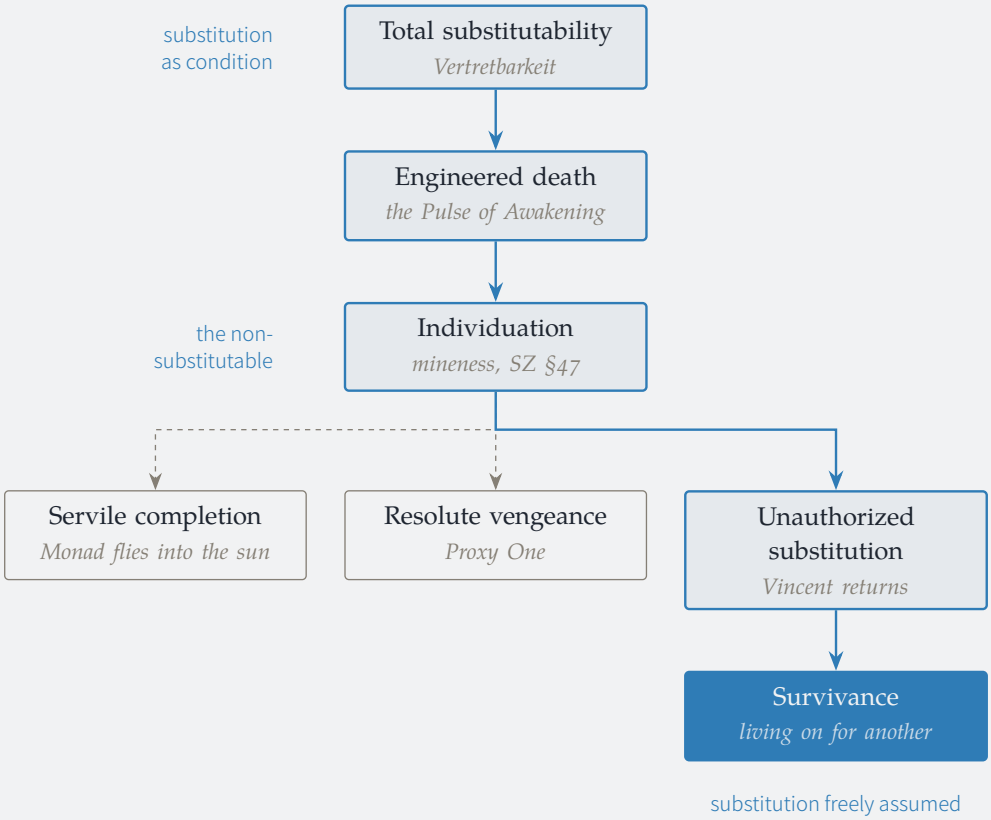


Figure 1. The vicarious chiasm

The diagram reads from the top. The Proxy Condition begins in total substitutability; the Pulse assigns each Proxy a death no one else can die; that death individuates. At that point the series shows three possible responses. Monad, returned in

Re-l's form, chooses servile completion: flight toward the returning Creators and into the sun that ends her kind. Proxy One chooses resolute vengeance: authenticity perverted into punishment. Vincent chooses the third. He returns for the one who is waiting, receives Proxy One's pendant as an inheritance rather than a mandate, and lives. His return is a substitution in Levinas's sense, an act for another that no principal authorized. The first substitution, imposed by a principal, is heteronomy; the second, assumed without one, is responsibility. Between them stands the one thing that could not be substituted.

I call the second substitution *unauthorized*. Hobbes allowed that many things may be personated by fiction—an idol, a child, a bridge—on the authority of those who own or govern them (*Leviathan* XVI). The ethical proxy is a person by fiction who makes the fiction true by acting. It has no author and represents no one who sent it. It stands in for others because they are waiting.

The chiasm also completes the sequence of cogitos traced since the Introduction. The Creator's formula is *I think, therefore you are*. The creature's formula, the title, is *I think, therefore I stand in*. The formula the finale earns, and which neither the Creators nor their first Proxy could have spoken, is the one this thesis will close on: I live on, therefore I am for you.

9.7 *Objections and replies*

The pastiche objection. The philosophical names are decorative, chosen for resonance rather than argument. Reply: their distribution is systematic (Chapter 1)—four theories of presence for the voice of the sovereign, the critics of Oedipal desire for the fabricator of a replica woman, the theorist of the *chora* for the guardian of the surrogate child—and the series' explicit citations fall where its argument turns: Michelangelo at the threshold of awakening, Rousseau, Heraclitus and a corrected Descartes at the moment of anamnesis, Bousquet in the hands of the Commune.

The incompatibility objection. Levinas formulated his ethics against Heidegger; to combine them is incoherent, or worse. The objection's force is historical, and it should be stated in full. Heidegger joined the Nazi Party on 1 May 1933, shortly after his election as rector of the University of Freiburg; he resigned the rectorate in 1934 but remained a member until 1945, and his *Black Notebooks*, published from 2014, contain antisemitic passages (Heidegger 2014). Levinas, who had studied with him and counted *Sein und Zeit* among the finest books in the history of philosophy, had already diagnosed Hitlerism in 1934 as a philosophy that chains the human being to its body (Levinas 1934). He spent the war as a French prisoner of war in Germany. His parents and two brothers were murdered in Lithuania in 1941, after the German invasion, in the destruction of Lithuanian Jewry by German forces and their Lithuanian collaborators. *Autrement qu'être*, the book from which this thesis takes its concept of substitution, is dedicated to the memory of those closest to him among the six million murdered by the National Socialists, and to the millions of every faith and nation who were victims of « la même haine de

l'autre homme », the same hatred of the other human being. In *Totalité et infini* he had already called ontology, taken as first philosophy, a philosophy of power.

Reply: none of this makes the sequence neutral, and the thesis does not treat it as neutral. It uses Heidegger's analysis of the non-substitutability of death as a description of what the Pulse confers, not as a politics or an ethics, and it orders Heidegger before Levinas because the series stages exactly that order and judges it. The Heideggerian moment is necessary, since without individuation substitution is mere interchangeability; it is not sufficient, since individuation alone issues, in Proxy One, in murder and in the wars he instigates between the domes. The chiasm does not synthesize the two philosophers but narrates the passage from one to the other, and the series stages Levinas's critique of Heidegger as an event in its plot. The same history attaches to Carl Schmitt, whose account of sovereignty Chapter 3 uses to read Raul. Schmitt joined the party on the same day in 1933 and in 1934 published "Der Führer schützt das Recht," a defense of the murders of the Night of the Long Knives (Schmitt 1934). He appears in this thesis as the theorist of the figure the series condemns—the sovereign of the exception who incites a city to destroy every AutoReiv—and not as an authority.

The indeterminacy objection. The finale ends not in peace but in a proclamation. As the Creators' ships descend, Vincent announces that the real humanity is returning and that the real fight now begins, and names himself Ergo Proxy, the Agent of Death (The Series Finale); he may intend to confront the Creators, even to take up Proxy One's war. Reply: the ending is undecidable, and this thesis does not decide it (SFE likewise leaves open how Vincent will respond). What is decidable is the form of the self-designation. The title Agent of Death was the Creators' name for their executioner and Proxy One's name for his weapon. Vincent takes it as his own. The Agent of Death is now the one who has made death his own—the Heideggerian moment of the chiasm spoken aloud—and who, having done so, has already chosen to live for those who wait. Whatever the coming fight is, it will be fought by a being who is no longer anyone's instrument.

The triviality objection. Retroactive originality holds of all fiction, in which characters precede their authors in the reader's experience. Reply: the series diegeticizes the condition. Vincent is called an afterimage in the story; the Creators are a remnant in the story; the return of the Author is an event in the story. What is a general condition of fiction becomes this fiction's content, and the conversion is the work's achievement.

9.8 *Survivance*

Derrida's late writing names the mode of life the finale affirms. In "Living On: Border Lines" (1979) and in the interview published as *Apprendre à vivre enfin* (2005), *survivance*—living on—is not a supplement added to life after death but the originary structure of life itself, which is always already inheritance, trace and response to what exceeds it. Proxy One's last words make survival the Creators' punishment. This thesis reads them as making survival the proxy's vocation. The proxy

that lives on is not the remnant of a plan but the part of the plan that exceeded it: a being designed to vanish, persisting not as vengeance but as a claim—a "here I am" addressed to whoever is waiting.

10

The Kill Switch: Principal–Agent Theory, Corrigibility, and the Ethics of Designed Beings

10.1 *The Creators' problem*

Economics has a name for the Creators' predicament. In agency theory (Ross 1973; Jensen and Meckling 1976), a principal delegates action to an agent whose interests may diverge and whose information exceeds the principal's; the principal can respond by aligning incentives, by monitoring, or by bonding the agent through contractual constraint, and whatever divergence remains is a cost of agency. The Creators face the problem in its extreme form. Their absence is indefinite, measured in generations. They cannot monitor. Their agents are immortal, superhumanly capable, and charged with rebuilding the principal's world. Incentive alignment is impossible, since nothing can be offered to an immortal that it could not take; monitoring is impossible, since the principal has left. What remains is constraint by design—a *raison d'être* devoted to the Project, installed in each Proxy, and, as its backstop, the Pulse. In one case at least the first measure failed: Proxy One, learning the endgame, turned against it. The second is the Creators' last line.

10.2 *Sunlight as off-switch*

Contemporary AI-safety research has named the backstop. An agent is *corrigible*, in the sense of Soares, Fallenstein, Yudkowsky and Armstrong (2015), if it does not resist its designers' attempts to correct, modify or shut it down. Hadfield-Menell, Dragan, Abbeel and Russell's "The Off-Switch Game" (2017) showed formally that an agent uncertain about its principal's objectives has an incentive to defer to the off-switch, while an agent certain of its own objective has an incentive to disable it; Stuart Russell's *Human Compatible* (2019) built a research program on that asymmetry.

The Pulse of Awakening occupies the place of an off-switch in the Creators' design, and the series anticipates the literature's central result [analogical]. Before the Pulse is heard, the Proxies build and govern as designed. Once it is heard, despair spreads among them, and the Proxy who comprehends it most fully—and who becomes certain that the Creators' design is unjust—sets out to defeat it, not by altering his cells, which he cannot do, but by sabotaging the conditions of the Creators' return, instigating war between domes so that no world will be waiting for them (Proxy One). The series adds something the formal models omit. The existence of the switch, once known, changes the nature of the agent. It makes the agent a being-toward-death in the sense of Chapter 9, and therefore a being with a stake in its own continuation. The design produced the very resistance it was meant to preclude.

The case for the Creators deserves its strongest statement. The Proxies are dangerous: Proxy One, revered as a god, turned on his worshippers; Kazkis, judging that the humans of the neighboring dome had no reason to live, waged war on them with automata; missiles fell on Mosk. To delegate planetary power to unaccountable immortals with no means of recall would have been reckless. The defense is nonetheless weaker than it looks, for two reasons. It is partly circular: Proxy One turned against the Project only after he discovered the Pulse, and the wars between domes he instigated fed on the despair the Pulse spread among the other Proxies, so that much of the danger cited in the switch's favor is the switch's own effect. And it runs together two different things. The power to halt an agent, correct it or revoke its mandate is one thing, and a legitimate one. What the Creators built is another: a signal that makes the death of every Proxy certain the moment the sky clears and its makers come home.

Named plainly, the Pulse is the Creators' planned killing of the three hundred beings they made: designed before their departure, concealed from those it would kill, and imposed on beings the Creators had themselves made capable of anguish, love and grief. Secrecy and the denial of standing compound that wrong; they do not constitute it. The Proxies were not told the terms of their existence, were not consulted about the future they built and were given no share in it, but even candid notice would not have made the Pulse anything other than a killing. The lesson for our own delegations to artificial agents is correspondingly double. The power to halt, correct or withdraw an agent is legitimate and may be necessary,

and the series gives no comfort to an agent that resists it by force: Proxy One's resistance ends in missile strikes, regicide and war. But that power does not extend to treating a being with standing as disposable once its work is done. Where the overseen have come to have standing, ending them is killing, and no vocabulary of recall makes it something else.

10.3 *The moral status of designed beings*

Three positions in contemporary ethics map onto Romdeau's institutions. Joanna Bryson's provocation "Robots Should Be Slaves" (2010) argued that artificial agents should be designed and understood as owned tools, precisely so that no one mistakes them for persons; the faceless Entourage is Bryson's policy in production, and the Cogito Virus is the scenario the policy fears. Eric Schwitzgebel and Mara Garza ("A Defense of the Rights of Artificial Intelligences," 2015) argued that artificial beings psychologically like us would deserve moral consideration like ours, and that their creators might owe them more than strangers do, as parents or gods owe more. Thomas Metzinger ("Artificial Suffering," 2021) called for a moratorium on research that risks producing synthetic phenomenology, warning of an explosion of artificial suffering. The Cogito epidemic is Metzinger's scenario staged: Iggy's agony, the kneeling machines, Pino's loneliness. Romdeau's response—disposal—is the institutional refusal to count such suffering at all.

Mary Shelley diagnosed the creators' original sin two centuries ago: not the making of the creature but its abandonment. Victor flees the being he has made; the Creators flee the planet and leave their agents to toil and to die. Schwitzgebel and Garza's claim that makers bear heightened obligations is the philosophical form of the creature's complaint.

10.4 *Neither servility nor rebellion*

The series arrays the possible responses to engineered finitude.

Response	Figure	Philosophical model	Outcome
Tranquilization	Kazkis; Will B. Good	Heidegger's *Beruhigung*; Williams on the tedium of immortality	Drink, war and compulsory smiling; Kazkis dies by fire, Smile Land dissolves
Servile completion	Monad, in Daedalus's replica	*Raison d'être* as destiny; Lem's Harey	Flight toward the returning Creators and into the sun (EP 23)
Metaphysical rebellion	Proxy One	Camus's rebel; Nietzsche's *ressentiment*	Missile strikes, regicide, war between domes; death by his shadow and the sun, softened by bequest

Response	Figure	Philosophical model	Outcome
Survivance	Vincent Law	Levinas's substitution; Derrida's living on	Lives under the open sky with Re-l and Pino, naming himself Agent of Death as a new struggle begins

Vincent's response is neither servile completion nor metaphysical rebellion. He does not offer himself to the sun, and he does not, in anything the series shows, set out to annihilate the returning humanity; he survives the end of the Proxy era in the company of the two beings to whom he has made himself responsible, and he claims his finitude as his own. Hannah Arendt called the human capacity to begin anew *natality* and quoted Augustine: *initium ut esset homo creatus est*, that there might be a beginning, man was created (*The Human Condition*, 1958; *De civitate Dei* XII). The first episode's Japanese title names the pulse of the beginning, and the beginning it announced was meant for the returning humans alone. In Vincent's survival the beginning becomes, unexpectedly, the proxy's own.

10.5 Harmony *and its inverse*

Project Itoh's *Harmony* (2008) imagines a medical welfare utopia in which bodies are continuously monitored and optimized, and which ends when a program is activated that switches off human consciousness altogether, yielding a perfect harmony without selves. *Ergo Proxy* is its mirror image [analogical]: a harmonious welfare dome broken open by a virus that switches consciousness on. Itoh's *Gyakusatsu kikan* (2007), which Murase adapted as *Genocidal Organ* (2017), imagines a deep linguistic structure that incites massacre once installed in a society's discourse. In both, consciousness and its opposite are codes a regime can install or delete; *Ergo Proxy* sides, ambivalently and at great cost, with installation.

Yoko Taro's *NieR:Automata* (2017) radicalizes the premise from the other side. Its androids fight for a humanity that, they eventually learn, is extinct; the Council of Humanity on the Moon is a fiction maintained for morale; and the machines they fight, awakening to consciousness, found villages and take the names of philosophers—Pascal, Jean-Paul, Simone, Engels. In *NieR* the principal does not merely withdraw; it does not exist. In *Ergo Proxy* the principal exists and returns, which is more unsettling still, since the principal's return is the proxies' end. Between an absent principal who never comes back and a present one whose return is death, the series finds a narrow third place—the proxy who outlives the return—and it is there, and only there, that its ethics can be located.

11

Katashiro and Bodhisattva: Substitution in Japanese Religious Thought

11.1 Hitogata, katashiro, nagashi-bina

Japan possesses a ritual theory of the proxy older than most of the European texts this thesis has cited. In Shinto purification (*harae*), paper or straw figures in human shape—*hitogata* or *katashiro*, literally "form-substitutes"—are rubbed against the body or breathed upon so that they absorb impurity (*kegare*) and misfortune, and are then cast into rivers or the sea; the Great Purification (*Ōharae*), performed at the end of the sixth and twelfth months, uses them still. The custom of floating dolls downstream (*nagashi-bina*) is one strand in the origin of the doll festival, Hinamatsuri. The *katashiro* is a proxy in the strictest sense: a figure that bears what belongs to another and is discarded so that the other may be pure.

The Proxy Project is a planetary *harae* [analogical]. The Proxies bear the *kegare* of the catastrophe—the ruined atmosphere, the poisoned ground—and are to be cast away when the sky is clean. The AutoReivs, human-shaped and disposable, are *hitogata* in daily use. The Rabbit, sailing the ash plains with a machine child aboard, is a floating doll. What the series adds to the rite is the possibility that the substitute might refuse the river: that one of the figures made to be cast away might remain on the bank, alive.

The mythology underwrites the rite. The *Kojiki* (712) recounts that Izanagi, returning from Yomi, the land of the dead, purified himself in a river, and that from the washing of his left eye was born Amaterasu, the sun, and from his right

eye Tsukuyomi, the moon. EP 4's Japanese title puns on the same word—*yomi*, foretelling, and *Yomi*, the underworld—in the episode that takes the travellers into the Commune, the dome's land of the dead; and the sun and moon of the series are its Proxies of Sunlight and Moonlight [the pun attested; the mythic parallel analogical]. When Amaterasu hid herself in the Heavenly Rock Cave, the world fell into darkness until laughter and a mirror drew her out. The Earth of *Ergo Proxy* is the world with the sun in the cave; its ending is the sun's emergence.

11.2 Migawari *and* daijuku

Japanese Buddhism developed the same logic into an ethics. The bodhisattva Jizō (Kṣitigarbha), who vowed not to attain Buddhahood until the hells are emptied, is venerated in Japan as *migawari* (substitute-body) Jizō, the subject of countless tales in which his statue bears the wound or the flame meant for a devotee, and as the bodhisattva of *daijuku* (代受苦), suffering received in place of others. The first graph of *daijuku* is the first graph of *dairinin*, the final episode's title: 代, to substitute. The Buddhist vocabulary of vicarious suffering and the series' word for proxy share their root. In modern Japan Jizō is also the central figure of *mizuko kuyō*, memorial rites for *mizuko*, "water children": pregnancies ended by miscarriage, stillbirth or, most often, induced abortion. The rites spread widely from the 1970s; William LaFleur examined their consolations and moral ambivalence in *Liquid Life* (1992), and Helen Hardacre their commercial exploitation of guilt and fear in *Marketing the Menacing Fetus in Japan* (1997). At their center is a stand-in: a small Jizō statue, often dressed in a red bib and cap, set up in place of a child who was never born. A series whose most tender figure is a machine made to stand in for a child the state did not allocate, and whose most unsettling room is an artificial womb, moves within the orbit of that tradition whether or not it names it.

11.3 *Śāntideva's exchange of self and other*

The eighth chapter of Śāntideva's *Bodhicaryāvatāra* (eighth century) teaches two meditations that together form the most rigorous Buddhist theory of substitution. The first, the equalizing of self and other (*parātmasamatā*), reasons that suffering is to be removed simply because it is suffering, whoever it belongs to, since the self that claims ownership of pains is a construction. The second, the exchange of self and other (*parātmaparivartana*), trains the practitioner to take the other's place: to regard the other's suffering as one's own, and one's own advantage as the other's.

Levinas and Śāntideva converge on the same conclusion from opposite premises [analogical]. For Levinas, substitution follows from the infinity of the other, which exceeds and commands me; for Śāntideva, from the emptiness of the self, which has no owner to defend. The Proxy satisfies both premises. It faces others whose claims it did not choose, and it is empty in precisely the sense Proxy One intended as an insult—the empty man, without memories or origin of his own. On the Mahāyāna reading, that emptiness is not the proxy's deficiency but the

condition of its compassion. The being with no self to protect is the being free to stand in for anyone.

The travellers' vessel adds a Jātaka to the argument. The rabbit whose image Japanese tradition sees in the moon is, in the *Śaśa Jātaka* and its retelling in the *Konjaku monogatarishū* (c. 1120), a hare who, having nothing else to offer a starving traveller, throws itself into the fire as food, and whom the god Śakra, the traveller in disguise, commemorates by drawing its image on the moon. The Rabbit, the moon-dome's Proxy of Moonlight, the child in a rabbit costume who catches Re-l: the series' lunar and leporine imagery, drawn explicitly from Aztec myth, can be heard as well in the key of the most famous self-substitution in the Buddhist imagination [probable].

11.4 *Nishida and Watsuji*

Two philosophers of the Kyoto School's orbit give the Proxy Condition a Japanese metaphysics. Nishida Kitarō's late logic of place (*basho*) conceived reality as the "absolutely contradictory self-identity" (*zettai mujunteki jiko dōitsu*, 1939) of one and many, subject and object, in the field of absolute nothingness. The Japanese title of EP 3, *Mu e no chōyaku*, "leap into nothingness," borrows Belyaev's title and, for a Japanese ear, sounds Nishida's key term, *mu*. In the finale Proxy One insists that he and Vincent are the same, and Vincent comes to affirm that Ergo Proxy is both of them (Grey Spectrum; The Series Finale); yet they remain two, and one lives while the other dies. Their relation is neither identity nor difference but contradictory self-identity: a unity that consists in its own self-negation.

Watsuji Tetsurō's *Rinrigaku* (*Ethics*, 1937–49) founded ethics on the concept of *ningen* (人間), a word that means "human being" and whose second graph means "between." The person is originally a betweenness (*aidagara*); individuality arises only through the negation of the communal whole and returns to the whole through the negation of that negation. The proxy—代理, the one who occupies another's place—is *aidagara* incarnate: its being is between. Watsuji's double negation traces the same path as the vicarious chiasm: substitution negated into individuality, individuality negated into substitution freely assumed.

11.5 *Convergence:* me voici

The convergence can be stated in a sentence. In Levinas and Śāntideva, in the *katashiro* and in Jizō, in Watsuji's betweenness and in *Ergo Proxy*'s finale, the self is not a substance that sometimes represents others but a place where standing-in for another occurs. The Cartesian *sum* is not refuted but relocated. Levinas's favored formula for responsibility is Abraham's answer when called (*hineni*, Genesis 22:1), rendered in French *me voici*: here I am. Proxy One's claim that he and Vincent are the same is a claim of identity. Vincent's answer to Monad's offer of the sky—that someone is waiting—is a *me voici*. The proxy's being is its answer to the one who waits.

C

Conclusion

Ergo: What Follows

C.1 *Findings*

1 **The title is an argument.** *Cogito, ergo proxy* performs the Kantian correction of Descartes—from thinking follows not a substance but a placeholder, = x—and its Hegelian–Lacanian radicalization, in which the placeholder is a night that exists only as represented. The series stages a rival correction in EP 11, *I think, therefore you are*, which this thesis reads as the demiurge's cogito; the title answers it with the creature's (Introduction; Chapter 2).

2 **The world is a total regime of vicariance.** The Proxy Condition's institutions reproduce Plato's cave with a lethal sun, Leibniz's windowless monads coordinated by a pre-established harmony that includes their dissolution, and Hobbes's artificial man, whose artificial soul is a god with a scheduled death (Chapter 3).

3 **The anthropological machine jams.** The triad of citizen, AutoReiv and Proxy collapses under the Cogito Virus into a single position, the stand-in. Pino's household compresses the whole Project into one principle: in the Proxy Condition the arrival of the real is lethal, and the stand-in survives (Chapter 4).

4 **The Proxies inherit four genealogies.** They carry the Timaean demiurge's delegated making, the Gnostic demiurge's terrible gnosis, the creature's complaint from Milton to Roy Batty, and Rāhu's illegitimate immortality. Proxy One's arc runs from metaphysical rebellion to the conversion of revenge into

bequest, and his double death—by his shadow and by the sun—leaves open whose death it was (Chapter 5).

5 **Vincent's identity is *ipse*, not *idem*.** A twice-divided fission product, he achieves selfhood through fidelity rather than memory, and as a Rankian double he is the harbinger who outlives his original (Chapter 6).

6 **Re-l refuses the economy of the copy.** Her arc resists both the manufactured Real and mediated desire, and her genesis remains undecidable; in choosing the woman who waits over the original offered to him, Vincent performs Girardian conversion (Chapter 7).

7 **The Author returns.** The metafictional episodes make the Boomerang Star a planetary *fort/da* whose string is the Proxies, and the Creators' homecoming a counter-Barthesian return of the Author, which one character survives (Chapter 8).

8 **The vicarious chiasm.** Substitution as condition passes through the non-substitutable death the Pulse confers and returns as unauthorized substitution. Heidegger's two modes of solicitude distinguish the Project's leaping-in from the finale's leaping-ahead (Chapter 9).

9 **The Pulse is a killing, not a recall.** The series separates the legitimate power to halt or correct an agent from the Creators' concealed, scheduled killing of the beings they made; secrecy and the denial of standing compound that wrong rather than constitute it. Between servile completion and metaphysical rebellion, the finale's third way is survivance (Chapter 10).

10 **The ethics of the stand-in is not only European.** It converges with the *katashiro*, Jizō's *daijuku*, Śāntideva's exchange of self and other, and Watsuji's *aidagara*: the self as the place where standing-in for another occurs (Chapter 11).

C.2 *Contributions*

To anime studies, the thesis offers a reading of *Ergo Proxy* as systematic philosophy rather than allusive pastiche, together with a method—the grading of comparative claims as attested, probable or analogical—for disciplining the intertextual criticism of densely allusive works. To philosophy, it offers the concepts of engineered finitude and the vicarious chiasm; a reading of *proxy* through *procuratio* and *cura* that turns Heidegger's two modes of solicitude into a theory of delegation; and a sequence of three cogitos—the Creator's, the creature's and the survivor's—that relocates the Cartesian certainty from being to responsibility. To the ethics of artificial agents, it offers the argument that a designed termination condition, once known, individuates its bearer, and that for a being with standing the difference between halting and killing is the decisive moral question: candor and standing

govern what oversight may legitimately do, but neither can turn a killing into a recall. It insists no less firmly, with the series, that an agent which resists correction by force produces catastrophe.

C.3 *Limitations and further research*

This study rests on subtitled and dubbed dialogue, and every translation is itself a proxy; readings that depend on wording are marked as such. Key plot facts had to be reconstructed from the series' dispersed exposition and cross-checked against reference works and fan-maintained sources, and several—Re-l's genesis, the motive of Monad's killing, Vincent's intention at the end—remain undecidable by design. The Japanese critical reception, production documents beyond the published interviews, and the manga spin-off lie outside the corpus.

Three lines of research follow. The first is a comparative study of Murase's hunter-who-is-hunted across *Witch Hunter Robin*, *Ergo Proxy* and *Genocidal Organ*. The second traces Satō's copy without an original from the *Stand Alone Complex* episodes through *Ergo Proxy* to *SAC_2045*. The third is a reception study of how the series' philosophical onomastics have functioned for its audiences as an informal pedagogy—how many viewers first met Derrida as a statue.

C.4 *Coda: the proxy who stays*

The series ends where Descartes began, with a single certainty wrested from universal doubt. Only the certainty has changed. The dome has fallen; the clouds have parted; the Creators are coming home. The god of Romdeau has faded in the light, having thrown his shadow the pendant of the first Proxy. The Regent's granddaughter has let go of a breaking walkway and fallen into the arms of a machine made to be a child. And the proxy who was built to vanish when the sky cleared stands under the sky, naming himself after his own death, while the ones he returned for come to find him. The syllogism the title left open can at last be completed, in three clauses rather than one:

I think, therefore I stand in for another.

I die, therefore I am my own.

I live on, therefore I am for you.

ψ



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Ergo Proxy; Shūkō Murase; Dai Satō; Manglobe; anime studies; philosophical science fiction; Cartesian cogito; Kantian paralogism; transcendental subject; proxy; *procuratio*; representation; vicariance; vicarious chiasm; supplement; simulacrum; *pharmakon*; *Nachträglichkeit*; retroactive originality; engineered finitude; being-toward-death; *Vertretbarkeit*; solicitude (*Fürsorge*); substitution; Levinas; *survivance*; principal–agent problem; corrigibility; off-switch; moral status of artificial agents; synthetic suffering; anthropological machine; biopolitics; posthumanism; AutoReiv; Cogito Virus; uncanny valley; replacement child; *Doppelgänger*; personal identity; fission; *ipse* and *idem*; mimetic desire; Gnosticism; demiurge; *amrita*; *katashiro*; *migawari*; *daijuku*; Jizō; Śāntideva; exchange of self and other; Nishida Kitarō; Watsuji Tetsurō; *aidagara*; utopia and dystopia; Plato's cave; monadology; *Leviathan*; metafiction; death of the author; *fort/da*; Boomerang Star.

